

Deriving clause incorporation in Inuktitut*

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Abstract: While previous research on incorporation has mainly focused on how (typically uninflected) nouns come to be incorporated into verb complexes, it is less well known that some languages also permit the incorporation of complex verbal constituents (e.g. Pittman, 2009; Barrie and Mathieu, 2016; McKenzie, 2022). In this paper, I investigate a previously underdescribed construction in Inuktitut (Inuit-Yupik-Unangan), in which an embedded clause is morphologically incorporated into a higher affixal verb of possession ‘have’, creating an existential. The embedded nominal arguments are stranded and case marked like antipassive objects rather than with the expected ERG and ABS morphology. I argue that the incorporated element is a pseudorelative clause, a CP-sized predicate of a small clause related to its nominal subject by control (e.g., Cinque 1995), based on structural parallels with pseudorelatives found cross-linguistically. Clause incorporation as opposed to noun incorporation arises in Inuktitut because the incorporating verb takes the entire pseudorelative structure, rather than a nominal, as its complement; this, in turn, motivates a postsyntactic model of incorporation that requires the syntactic structure as its input (e.g. Compton and Pittman, 2010; Yuan, 2025). Additionally, the case patterns found in incorporated clauses reveal that both ERG and ABS case assignment are tied to the extended CP domain (e.g. Compton, 2018; Carrier, 2020; Yuan, 2022), and are not associated with lower clausal fields such as the vP and TP domains.

1 Introduction

Although most prior work on the morphosyntax of incorporation has focused on the incorporation of (typically bare) nouns into verb complexes, it is also known that some languages also permit the incorporation of complex verbal constituents (e.g., VPs, vPs, and even TPs) (Baker, 1988; Pittman, 2006, 2009; Wojdak, 2008; Compton and Pittman, 2010; Johns, 2014; Barrie and Mathieu, 2016; McKenzie, 2019, 2022; Yuan, 2025, a.o.). In a comprehensive typological survey, however, Olthof (2020a,b) finds no unambiguous instances of *incorporated clauses* and speculates that they either do not exist or are, at the very least, exceedingly rare. But the very possibility of clause incorporation raises novel questions for the syntax-morphology interface. For instance, how might existing analyses of noun incorporation be extended to the incorporation of complex constituents that contain their own nominal arguments, and what might clause incorporation reveal about the morphosyntactic underpinnings of complex word-formation more broadly?

In this paper, I demonstrate that the incorporation of embedded clauses is in fact attested in (Eastern Canadian) Inuktitut and related languages, arising in a particular type of construction I refer to as the *clause-incorporating existential*. As shown in (1a), a verb bearing so-called ‘participial’ clause type morphology is incorporated into another verb *-qaq* ‘have’, which functions here as a verb of existence (incorporating verbs are underlined throughout the paper for clarity). The existential pivot, interpreted as the subject of the embedded verb, is stranded and surfaces with so-called ‘modalis’ (MOD) case, the case also used to mark antipassive objects. The incorporated clause displays both similarities and differences with the standard declarative construction, (1b), which bears the same clause type morphology but contains an ABS subject and lacks the indefinite reading found in (1a). The incorporated clause moreover differs from other incorporated verbal elements in the language, which do not bear clause-type morphology (nor require MOD case on any stranded nouns).

*Acknowledgments will be included in a later version of this paper.

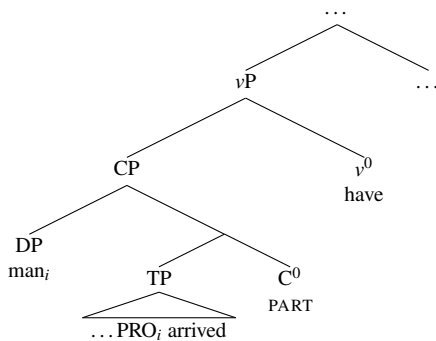
(1) **Incorporated vs. standalone ‘participial’ clauses in Inuktitut**

- a. anguti-mik **tikit-tu-qaq**-tuq
 man-MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A man arrived.’
- b. anguti **tikit-tuq**
 man.ABS arrive-PART.3SG.S
 ‘The man arrived.’

Although this construction appears frequently in documentary sources and corpora as a strategy to express indefinite subjects, it has neither been systematically investigated nor acknowledged as an instance of clause incorporation, as previous work on incorporation in the Inuit-Yupik languages has mainly centered around that of nominal direct objects (Sadock 1980, 1986, 1991; Woodbury and Sadock 1986; van Geenhoven 1998, 2002; Johns 1999, 2007b, 2009; Compton and Pittman 2010; Woodbury 2017; Yuan 2025, a.o., though see Pittman 2006, 2009 on incorporated verbal constituents). The primary goals of this paper are therefore: (i) to uncover the morphosyntactic properties of this construction, (ii) to connect these properties to the underpinnings of incorporation and complex (polysynthetic) word-formation in Inuktitut more generally, and (iii) to address both its productive yet restricted nature and its typological rarity. Additionally, we will see that the clause-incorporating existential offers a new empirical window into the case and agreement system of the language, as the nominal arguments introduced within incorporated clauses do not display the same morphosyntactic patternings as their counterparts in non-incorporated clauses.

I propose that the incorporated element in (1a) is a CP in category, but it lacks the higher CP-level ϕ -probes present in root declarative clauses. This bleeds ERG and ABS case assignment to DPs in that clause, providing novel evidence that case assignment in the Inuit languages is specifically keyed to the extended CP domain (e.g. Compton, 2018; Yuan, 2018, 2022; Carrier and Compton, 2025), rather than lower projections such as TP and vP. Moreover, I argue that the incorporated CP is a *pseudorelative*, that is, a clause-sized predicate of a small clause, related to its subject by control (e.g. Cinque, 1992; Rafel, 2000; Koopman and Sportiche, 2014; Moulton and Grillo, 2015). Although previous work on pseudorelatives (mainly on European languages) has generally focused on their usages in perception verb constructions rather than existentials, my proposal is motivated by strong empirical parallels between these construction types. A simplified schematization of this analysis is provided in (2) (note that (2) assumes Matushansky’s (2019) treatment of small clauses, with the subject represented as the specifier of the clausal predicate).

(2) **Pseudorelative structure in Inuktitut (preliminary)**



In (2), the subject and the embedded clause are both within the scope of the incorporating light verb *-qaq* ‘have’, yet it is the clause that gets incorporated. I propose that clause incorporation arises in Inuktitut due to a confluence of language-specific factors, including the affixal (morphologically bound) nature of the existential verb *-qaq* ‘have’, the ability for *-qaq* ‘have’ to select nominal and clausal complements alike, and a postsyntactic mechanism for incorporation that takes the syntactic structure as its input (e.g. Compton and Pittman, 2010;

Yuan, 2025). That these factors happen to simultaneously hold in Inuktitut explains the aforementioned cross-linguistic rarity of clause incorporation.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. In §2, I overview key properties of Inuktitut morphosyntax relevant to the paper. A detailed investigation of the clause-incorporating existential is then presented: after detailing the grammatical properties of the embedded clause and its nominal arguments in §3, I argue in §4 that the incorporated clause is a pseudorelative (small clause) predicate embedded under an affixal verb of existence. §5 then provides an account of case assignment in the clause-incorporating existential, building on the findings of the previous sections. Finally, §6 models the morphological incorporation of embedded clauses and situates these findings within the broader typology of incorporation.

2 Overview of Inuktitut morphosyntax

I start by presenting key properties of Inuktitut and Inuit, focusing on its case and agreement system, the functions of participial clause type morphology, and the incorporation of nominal and verbal constituents.

2.1 Language background and key morphosyntactic properties

The Inuit languages (of the Inuit-Yupik-Unangan language family) are a continuum of dialects spanning the North American Arctic and Greenland. This paper focuses primarily on the varieties of the Inuktitut language spoken in various communities in the Qikiqtaaluk (Baffin Island) region of Nunavut,¹ although data from other varieties are provided wherever relevant.² Like other languages of the family, Inuktitut is polysynthetic, with a large number of derivational suffixes that encode verbs, adjectives, and adverbs, (3) (e.g. Fortescue, 2002, 2017; Cook and Johns, 2009; Compton, 2012; Compton and Bliss, 2023).

(3) Complex ‘polysynthetic’ word in Inuktitut

uqa-limaar-vi-liu(ng)-inna-nngit-tunga

speak-all.of-LOC.NMLZ-make-always-NEG-PART.1SG.S

‘I was not always making libraries.’ (IG; Compton and Pittman 2010, p. 2168)

Although the Inuit languages have been described as having base SOV word order, in Inuktitut SVO is also frequently attested in information-structurally neutral contexts (e.g. Carrier, 2023). Regardless, I assume that the language is head-final. Complex words adhere to the Mirror Principle, so word-internal morpheme order corresponds to syntactic height or scope (Fortescue, 1980; Baker, 1985). Verbs minimally begin with a root and end with clause type morphology (e.g. Fortescue, 1983; Dorais, 1988),³ and various vP- and TP-level suffixes may be (optionally) found between the two. The examples in (4) also show that verbal agreement is morphologically sensitive to clause type. This has led to the proposal that both subject and object agreement is located in the CP-domain, a point that will be reinforced below as well as throughout the paper (e.g. Johns, 2007b; Compton, 2016, 2018; Yuan, 2021, 2022; Carrier and Compton, 2025; Compton and Yuan, to appear).

¹A broader term, Inuktitut, is used by the Government of Nunavut to encompass Inuktitut and Inuinnaqtun.

²Unless explicitly indicated, uncited examples were elicited by the author between 2017-2019, in Iqaluit, Nunavut and remotely (online). Following the conventions of Yuan 2025, this paper indicates for each linguistic example the community of the Inuktitut speaker that produced it. The following abbreviations will be used for examples elicited by the author: AB = Arctic Bay (Ikpiarjuk), IG = Iglulik, PG = Pangnirtung (Pangniqtuuq), PI = Pond Inlet (Mittimatalik), IQ = Iqaluit, SN = Sanirajak. For examples cited from published sources on Inuktitut and other languages, the following additional abbreviations, for both individual communities and broader regions are used, whenever the information is available: CH = Coral Harbour (Salliq), IT = Itivimiut, KL = Kalaallisut, L = Labrador, NB = North Baffin, NK = Nunavik, SB = South Baffin, TR = Tarramiutut.

³This morphology is often also referred to as ‘mood’ in the Inuit literature. However, as this usage of these terms differs from how it is typically used outside of Inuit linguistics, I continue to refer to the relevant distinctions in terms of clause type, following Compton and Yuan to appear.

(4) **Clause type and agreement morphology**

- a. nirua-runna-**tait**
choose-can-PART.2SG.S/3SG.O
'You can pick it.' (AB)
- b. ani-qu-api-**guk**
leave-tell-small/dear-IMP.2SG.S/3SG.O
'Tell the dear one to leave.' (TR; Beach 2011, pp. 167)

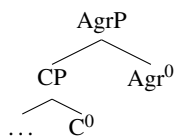
Although these clause type and agreement morphs are often realized as portmanteaux, they are comprised of distinct syntactic heads, which may be analyzed as subprojections of an articulated CP domain in the sense of Rizzi 1997 (see e.g. Johns 1992, Bittner and Hale 1996b, Compton and Pittman 2010, Compton 2018, and Yuan 2021, 2022 for various versions of this idea). One piece of evidence for this comes from the fact that clause type and agreement morphology may in certain contexts be separated by other suffixes, (5).⁴

(5) **Clause type < ϕ -morphology**

- numaa-suk-**tu**-inna-**it**
sad-feel-PART-every-3PL.S
'All of them are sad.' (AB)

The morpheme order in (5) additionally reveals that ϕ -agreement is located syntactically above clause type morphology, suggesting a clausal periphery as in (6). The clause type morphology expones the head I label 'C' for convenience; the label 'Agr' is used here as a catch-all for subject agreement and (if present) object agreement.⁵ In this paper, I am largely agnostic about whether subject agreement and object agreement also instantiate separate heads (as assumed by, for instance, Yuan 2022⁶), since our focus is simply the presence or absence of ϕ -morphology in standalone vs. incorporated clauses.

(6) **Extended CP-domain in Inuktitut**



As seen in (1), the embedded clause within the clause-incorporating existential bears so-called 'participial' morphology. Root declarative clauses in Inuktitut also typically surface with this morphology, rather than the 'indicative' clause type morphology standardly used to mark declaratives in other varieties such as Kalaallisut (in Inuktitut, the indicative is somewhat pragmatically marked). Participial morphology is *t*- or *j*-initial, depending on whether the stem to which it attaches ends in a consonant or vowel, (7). Throughout this paper, intransitive and transitive verbs bearing participial clause type morphology will be referred to as 'participial clauses' as shorthand.

⁴On the morphological integration of noun-modifying suffixes into the verb complex, see Snigaroff 2024 for an analysis of similar facts in distantly related Aleut.

⁵Compton (2018) considers a single projection, ForceP, for clause type and agreement; this is equally compatible with the assumption here since ForceP is considered the highest CP-level projection (Rizzi, 1997). Mikkelsen et al. (2026) refer to the clause type and agreement projections separately as MoodP and CP, with the latter dominating the former; this is likewise easily translatable into the current system.

⁶Yuan (2022) observes that object ϕ -morphology often appears outside of subject ϕ -morphology, and thus proposes two agreeing heads, AgrO⁰ and AgrS⁰, with the former structurally higher than the latter. However, as a reviewer notes, the opposite order is also attested in certain contexts, as discussed by Compton (2018) and others. This paper abstracts away from the relative ordering of these elements, since the only important point for our purposes is that ϕ -agreement is structurally higher than clause type morphology, as depicted in (6).

(7) **Phonologically-conditioned allomorphy in participial morphology**

- a. malik-tunga vs. taku-junga
 follow-PART.1SG.S see-PART.1SG.S
 ‘I follow’ vs. ‘I see’
- b. malik-tagit vs. taku-jagit
 follow-PART.1SG.S/2SG.O see-PART.1SG.S/2SG.O
 ‘I follow you’ vs. ‘I see you’

Verbs bearing participial clause type morphology are generally considered to have been historically derived from *nominal participles* (e.g. Fortescue et al., 2011), hence the terminology. However, it is debatable to what extent this morphology is *synchronically* nominal in root declaratives (as in (7)) and in embedded contexts (as in the clause-incorporating existentials investigated in this paper); participial morphology could be analyzed as uniformly clausal, uniformly nominal, or both depending on the syntactic environment. The position I take in this paper is that it is now entirely part of the verbal extended sequence, having been fully integrated into the complementizer system of the language (see also Johns 2000; Mahieu 2009; Compton 2018, 2019). For our purposes, this means that the participial morphology seen in the clause-incorporating existential construction expones C^0 , as (6) above.⁷

Transitive sentences in the Inuit languages display an ergative (ERG-ABS) case alignment, though the ergative construction seen in (8a) alternates with an antipassive (ABS-MOD) construction, (8b). Verbal antipassive morphology varies depending on the choice of verb stem and does not always surface overtly; moreover, antipassivization may apply to both verbal roots and suffixes (e.g. Fortescue, 1996; Schmidt, 2003; Spreng, 2006, 2012; Yuan, 2018). Importantly, in contrast to how antipassives are typically described cross-linguistically (e.g. Polinsky, 2017), antipassives in Inuktitut and other Eastern Canadian varieties do not reflect an argument struc-

⁷In contrast, Johns 1992 proposes that participial intransitive and transitive declaratives (in both root and embedded contexts) are synchronically null copular constructions whose predicates are nominalized participial verbs. See also Yuan 2013 and Carrier and Compton 2025, building on Johns, as well as the summary in Compton 2017b. Under this analysis, sentences like (ia-b) would have the alternative parses given below, where the ABS argument is invariably the subject. The transitive subject in (ib) would be reinterpreted as a possessor of the nominal passive verb, as supported by the homophony between GEN and ERG case (-up) and between possessor/possessee and subject/object participial agreement when the object is in the 3rd person.

(i) **Alternative parses for intransitive and transitive participial constructions**

- a. (pro) mumiq-tuq
 (3SG.PRON.ABS) dance-PART
 ‘S/he dances.’ (Or: ‘S/he is a dancing one.’)
- b. Taiviti-up igalaaq sura-qqau-ja-nga
 David-GEN window.ABS break-REC.PST-PASS.PART-3SG/3SG
 ‘David broke the window (earlier today).’ (Or: ‘The window is David’s earlier today broken one.’)

However, a major challenge for this proposal as a synchronic state of affairs is that it cannot extend to participial clauses containing 1st/2nd person ABS arguments, as in the examples in (7). This is because the verbal agreement forms cross-referencing such arguments do not have possessive analogues (as possesseees are only ever in the 3rd person). See also Carrier and Compton 2025 for additional morphosyntactic differences (in response to this, Carrier and Compton 2025 propose a syntactic split, whereby only the participial clauses containing 1st/2nd person ABS arguments are verbal). This proposal also requires a different analysis for declarative participial clauses vs. all other clause types in the language (including the declarative indicative clause, which is morphologically nearly identical, save for the initial consonant).

Another, more nuanced approach might be to take *only* embedded participial clauses (including those in the clause-incorporating existential) to be nominalized. Under this treatment, embedded participial morphology would be analyzed as n^0 rather than C^0 . In contrast to the above, this hybrid treatment of participial morphology does not impact the core findings of the paper either way. This is because embedded participial morphology is Merged high in the structure, above TP and NegP and thus after the arguments of the embedded verb have been introduced (see §3.1). The incorporated constituent would therefore still be clausal under this analysis, albeit subsequently nominalized. For simplicity, however, I ultimately adopt the idea that participial clauses are not syntactically different from any other clause type, in both root and embedded contexts. Following Mahieu 2009, I assume that the analysis above represents just the *diachronic* pathway of participial clauses but not their synchronic status, the originally nominal morphology having been reanalyzed as complementizers.

tural change such as detransitivization. Objects of antipassivized verbs in these varieties are not necessarily interpreted as non-specific or indefinite and are not obviously analyzable as oblique (e.g. Bok-Bennema 1991; Johns 1999, 2001, 2006, 2017; Beach 2011; Carrier 2017, 2020; Yuan 2018, 2021, 2022, cf. Baker 1988; Wharram 2003; Branigan and Wharram 2019). This is highly relevant to the current paper, as embedded nominal arguments in the clause-incorporating existential construction are obligatorily MOD.

(8) **Ergative and antipassive case and agreement patternings**

- a. Taiviti-up igalaaq sura-qqau-janga
David-ERG window.ABS break-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O
'David broke the window (earlier today).'
- b. Taiviti igalaar-mik surak-si-qqau-juq
David.ABS window-MOD break-AP-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
'David broke a/the window (earlier today).' (AB)

Up to two nominals may be indexed by ϕ -morphology, and these nominals are necessarily ERG and ABS, respectively. As seen in constructions with three or more non-oblique arguments, as in (9), other core nominals in the clause are not cross-referenced by ϕ -agreement and are MOD.⁸ MOD case may also be used to mark certain nominals serving as adjuncts (e.g., instruments), but the MOD nominals in this paper will be limited to core arguments.

(9) **Double and triple object constructions in Inuktitut**

- a. Miali-up Jaani tuni-qqau-janga ajjinnguar-mik
Miali-ERG Jaani.ABS give-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O picture-MOD
'Miali gave Jaani a picture.' (IG)
- b. (pro) Jaani qiturnga-nik tuni-si-qu-jara mamaq-tu-nik
(1SG.ERG) Jaani.ABS offspring-PL.MOD give-AP-want-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O tasty-PART-PL.MOD
'I want Jaani to give the children candy (lit. tasty things).' (IG)

This paper will defend the generalizations about Inuktitut case and agreement summarized in (10). The morphosyntactic properties observed in the clause-incorporating existential construction will provide novel evidence for these points.

(10) **Case and agreement in Inuktitut are tied to the extended CP domain**

- a. ERG and ABS cases (indirectly) reflect successful Agree with ϕ -probes located in the extended CP domain, while MOD case reflects no such ϕ -Agree relations
- b. No other functional heads (e.g., located in the TP- and vP-domains) are implicated in case assignment and ϕ -agreement

Both points in (10) have been raised in prior work on Inuit morphosyntax (e.g. Compton, 2018; Yuan, 2018, 2022; Carrier, 2020; Carrier and Compton, 2025; Mikkelsen et al., 2026). However, they diverge from most other accounts of ergative case and agreement systems (for Inuit and other languages), which instead generally implicate lower parts of the clause such as the vP and TP domains; it is likewise canonical to analyze ϕ -probes targeting subjects and objects as located in these domains (e.g. Chomsky, 2000). However, we will see that ERG and ABS in Inuktitut require the CP-level AgrP layer depicted in (6), while MOD case is assigned within vP. Leaving the details of such an analysis until §5, for now it suffices to remember that the distributions of ERG, ABS, and MOD cases are tied to syntactic height.

This case–height correlation is also relevant to embedded subjects. Although subjects usually surface vP-

⁸Though see Johns 2018, which documents the ability for MOD objects to be indexed by object agreement for some Labrador Inuttut speakers.

externally, in the clause-incorporating existential construction they appear within vP, under the verb *-qaq* ‘have’. As already indicated in (1) above, such subjects are MOD, not ABS (or ERG), an initial piece of support for the statements in (10).

2.2 Incorporation and arguments of incorporated elements

In general, noun incorporation in the world’s languages tends to be optional for any given transitive verb, its occurrence often correlating with a non-referential interpretation of the nominal object. In contrast, as shown in (11) below, noun incorporation in Inuktitut (as well as in the Inuit-Yupik languages more broadly) is obligatory with a small class of verbs, and is generally impossible otherwise. The obligatoriness of incorporation in Inuktitut may be one of the key factors in why the language permits incorporated clauses, against the cross-linguistically more typical picture, as I discuss further in §6.

The verbs that trigger incorporation are often called *affixal verbs* (or *denominal verbs*) in the literature, since they require a morphological host such as the nominal object (Mithun, 1986; Sadock, 1986, 1991; Johns, 2007b; Compton and Pittman, 2010).⁹ In general, affixal verbs in the Inuit languages tend to be somewhat semantically bleached compared to their standalone counterparts (Mithun 1999; Johns 2007b; Cook and Johns 2009, cf. Huijting 2024). In this paper, I follow Johns 2007b, 2009 in differentiating affixal (incorporating) vs. non-affixal (non-incorporating) verbs as light verbs (v^0 s) vs. lexical verbs (V^0 s), respectively, though this is not of analytical importance.

(11) Noun incorporation is obligatory with certain verbs

- a. **pitsi-tu**-vunga
dried.fish-consume-IND.1SG.S
‘I’m eating dried fish.’ (cf. *pitsik* ‘dried fish’)
- b. ***pitsi-mik** **tu**-vunga
dried.fish-MOD consume-IND.1SG.S
Intended: ‘I’m eating dried fish.’ (L; Johns 2007b, p. 541)

That incorporation has taken place in the examples throughout this paper is often signaled by regular morphophonological changes that may affect the final segment of the stem, such as deletion and progressive assimilation (e.g. Dorais, 1985; Bobaljik, 1996). Additionally, except in limited environments, incorporated elements generally do not surface with overt case or number morphology.

As pointed out by Sadock (1985, 1991) and Yuan (2025), however, this does not necessarily entail that incorporated elements lack case and number *syntactically*. Rather, these authors treat these features as underlyingly present but simply morphologically unrealized, due to the morphological subcategorization requirements in incorporation contexts, an assumption I follow in this paper. Indeed, the underlying case and number properties of incorporated nominals may be indicated by concord with stranded modifiers. As Sadock (1980) discusses, the example in (12) is particularly informative: the appearance of the plural MOD form *-nik* on *ataatsiq* ‘one’ reflects the fact that the incorporated object it modifies (a semantically singular *plurale tantum* noun) is also both MOD and morphosyntactically plural. This example additionally shows that the case of the incorporated object and its modifier is the same as that of antipassive objects (e.g. Baker, 1985).

⁹ In addition to the Inuit languages, other languages that have been reported to display obligatory noun incorporation with affixal verbs (possibly co-existing with the more ‘standard’ pattern of optional incorporation) include Halkomelem (Salishan; Gerdts and Hukari 2008), Nuu-chah-nulth and Kwakwaka (both Wakashan; Waldie 2004; Wojdak 2008; Sardinha 2017), Ojibwe (Algonquian; Mathieu 2013; Barrie and Mathieu 2016), and Chukchi and Koryak (both Chukotko-Kamchatkan; Kurebito 2001, 2017; Kantarovitch 2024), though there may be cross-linguistic differences concerning the productivity of the phenomenon.

(12) **Case concord on modifiers of incorporated nouns**

ataatsi-**nik** qamuti-qar-poq
 one-PL.MOD carriage-have-IND.3SG.S
 ‘He has one carriage.’ (KL; Sadock 1980, p. 309)

Incorporated elements in Inuktitut are additionally underlyingly syntactically phrasal, even though they are ultimately realized morphologically as complex heads (Compton, 2013). In (13a), the incorporated noun bears several adjectival suffixes (see also (3)); additionally, Inuktitut permits elements of category D, such as proper names and pronouns, to undergo incorporation, (13b-c), suggesting that incorporated nouns are not necessarily indefinite or non-referential, in contrast to the more typical cross-linguistic picture.

(13) **Incorporation of complex nominals and D-elements**

- a. **iglu-tsiava-nngua-qaq**-tuq
 house-great-pretend-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘(S)he has a great pretend house.’ (SB; Compton 2013, p. 3)
- b. Qallupilluq **Miali-tu**-niaq-pa?
 Qallupilluq.ABS Miali-consume-NR.FUT-INT.3SG.S
 ‘Is Qallupilluq going to eat Miali?’ (SB; Johns 2009, p. 191)
- c. Guuti **uvanga-liu**-lauq-tuq
 God.ABS 1SG.PRON-make-PST-PART.3SG.S
 ‘God made me.’ (AB)

For these reasons, in this paper I adopt the view that incorporated nouns in Inuktitut need not be structurally reduced, despite their morphologically uninflected appearance (contra, for instance, Compton and Pittman 2010, and Branigan and Wharram 2019). In addition to the above, Yuan (2025) demonstrates that incorporated nouns in the language are accessible to the syntactic operations (e.g., case assignment, ϕ -agreement, and movement) otherwise available to non-incorporated arguments, which would be difficult to maintain if they are inherently smaller.¹⁰ In §4 and beyond, we will also see that the CPs found in the clause-incorporating existential construction may appear as independent words in other contexts without discernable differences in structure or meaning, allowing us to generalize that, as a whole, incorporants—whether nominal or clausal—are not systematically smaller than their standalone counterparts.

Importantly, while most affixal verbs in Inuktitut incorporate nouns, certain affixal verbs instead embed complex verbal constituents. Previous authors have analyzed such constructions as involving restructuring or ECM (Pittman, 2006, 2009; Compton and Pittman, 2010; Yuan, 2018). Furthermore, as Pittman (2006) shows, the exact category of the embedded clauselet depends on the selectional requirements of the affixal verb. For instance, the affixal verb *-niraq* ‘say’ syntactically embeds a TP clause, as shown by the co-occurrence of overt matrix and embedded tense morphology in (14). Note that, as present tense is morphologically null (e.g. Hayashi, 2011), this is only evident in non-present tenses.

(14) **Finite TP embedded under affixal verb -niraq ‘say’**

Saila-up [_{TP} niri-**niar**]-nira-**qqau**-janga [_{TP} Alana tuktu-viniq-mit]
 Saila-ERG eat-NR.FUT-say-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O Alana.ABS caribou-former-MOD
 ‘Saila said [_{TP} Alana will be eating caribou meat].’ (SB; Compton 2017a, p. 299)

The example in (14) additionally shows that only the heads along the embedded functional spine end up morphologically incorporated into the matrix affixal verb, as the nominals thematically associated with the embedded verb are stranded.¹¹ Nonetheless, we can deduce that these nominals truly originate within the lower clause

¹⁰Some of the arguments from Yuan 2025 will be reproduced throughout this paper; see §3.3, §5.2, and §6.1 in particular.

¹¹This is comparable to the incorporation of nouns and adjectival suffixes along the nominal spine vs. the stranding of standalone

(as opposed to being generated in the matrix clause as proleptic arguments): the example in (15) shows that a sentential idiom may be embedded under the same affixal verb without losing its idiomatic meaning.

(15) **Sentential idiom embedded under affixal verb *-niraq* ‘say’**

[_{TP} tulugait qakuq-si-lir]-niraq-tangit
crow.PL.ABS white-INCP-PROG -say-PART.3SG.S/3PL.O

‘She said that [_{TP} Hell is freezing over].’

Lit.: ‘She said that [_{TP} the crows are starting to turn white].’ (PG; Yuan 2018, p. 213)¹²

The cases of the stranded nominal arguments are determined by the clausal syntax. For instance, the ERG-ABS(-MOD) case arrays in (14)-(15) are identical to those of transitive and double object constructions, though in these examples the matrix object ϕ -agreement indexes embedded ABS subjects rather than clausemate ABS objects. The morphosyntactic assumptions from §2.1 thus readily extend to these constructions: due to the truncated (non-phasal) nature of the embedded TP, matrix ϕ -agreement in the extended CP-domain may target the embedded subject.

Lastly, Inuktitut allows affixal verbs to embed constituents containing other affixal verbs. I mention this here because such constructions will occasionally feature in §3 and beyond. In (16), the embedded TP containing a noun-incorporating affixal verb *-tuq* ‘consume’ is incorporated into the higher ECM affixal verb *-niraq* ‘say’.

(16) **Affixal verbs may embed other affixal verbs**

Jamesie-up [_{TP} tuktu-mini-tu]-nira-qqau-janga [_{TP} Jaani]
Jamesie-ERG caribou-former-consume -say-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O Jaani.ABS

‘Jamesie said that Jaani ate caribou meat.’ (IQ)

To illustrate the syntactic assumptions laid out so far, a simplified and partial structure of (16) is given in (17) (setting aside issues of non-SOV word order). Again, what is crucial here is the idea that affixal verbs (v^0 s) may syntactically embed complex constituents—including, potentially, verbal constituents that project their own nominal arguments. Note also that, in line with the discussion above, I depict all nominal arguments in Inuktitut (incorporated or otherwise, and regardless of interpretation) uniformly as DPs in this paper (Longobardi 1994), though it may also be possible to represent them as determinerless yet referential NPs (Baker, 2003).¹³

modifiers (as in (13a) vs. (12)).

¹²As Yuan 2018 clarifies, the idiomatic expression in the embedded clause in (15) is a permutation of the actual saying given in (i) (this may be akin to English, ‘when pigs fly’ vs. ‘pigs are flying’).

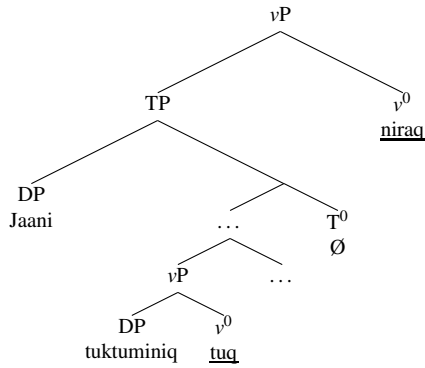
(i) **Original version of idiomatic expression in (15)**

tulugait qakuq-sip-patta
crow.PL.ABS white-INCP-COND.3P.S
‘When Hell freezes over.’

Lit.: ‘Only when the crows turn white.’ (PG; Yuan 2018, p. 212)

¹³This decision sidesteps the wider DP vs. NP debate for determinerless languages (see Salzmann 2018, 2020 for recent overviews of this issue). For the Inuit languages, Compton (2004) has proposed that all nouns are NPs, while Manlove (2015) has argued for a covert DP structure. As mentioned above, what is ultimately more important for our purposes is that incorporated nouns are syntactically identical in size to their standalone counterparts, whatever their category.

(17) **Partial structure of incorporation construction**



In sum, this section has discussed the following properties of Inuktitut morphosyntax:

- Participial clause type morphology instantiates C^0 in both root and embedded contexts.
- Case and ϕ -agreement patternings correspond to the presence or absence of Agree dependencies initiated by a ϕ -probe in the extended CP-domain, above C^0 . ERG and ABS arguments are Agreed with, while MOD arguments are not.
- Incorporation is driven by the affixal nature of certain verbs in the language, in that they require morphological hosts.
- Affixal verbs syntactically embed complex (phrasal) constituents, including verbal elements that project their own nominal arguments.

3 An initial syntax for the clause-incorporating existential

We now turn to the clause-incorporating existential construction, whose morphosyntactic profile both follows from and reinforces the properties of Inuktitut detailed above. Although there is no prior literature focusing on this construction, it is frequently attested in documentary sources, corpora, and texts.¹⁴ Therefore, this paper presents the first systematic description and analysis of the clause-incorporating existential, thus providing a blueprint for subsequent work on this and related topics. In this section, I introduce the construction and provide a basic syntax of the embedded clause and how it relates syntactically to both the embedded subject and the matrix affixal verb.

3.1 Key morphosyntactic properties

The clause-incorporating existential construction is one of many ways to express existence in Inuktitut, which, to my knowledge, all involve a morpheme that abstractly encodes ‘HAVE’. To appreciate the morphosyntax of

¹⁴Some examples are provided in (i):

(i) **Examples of clause-incorporating existentials from grammars and texts**

- a. TV-mi **su-mik** **suqutiginar-tu-qa-nngil-aq**
TV-LOC what-MOD be.interesting-PART-have-NEG-IND.3SG.S
‘There is nothing interesting on TV.’ (KL; Fortescue 1984, p. 138)
- b. nuvuja-lir-tu-alu-u-lir-mat immaqaa pirsi-nia-lir-tuq ullumi **ulluria-mik**
cloud-PROG-PART-big-be-PROG-CAUS.3SG.S perhaps blizzard-NR.FUT-PROG-PART.3SG.S today star-MOD
nuita-ju-qa-nngi-mat
be.visible-PART-have-NEG-CAUS.3SG.S
‘It’s very cloudy, no stars at all. . . there may be a snowstorm.’ (Patsauq 2021, p. 65; glosses from Mahieu 2021)

this particular construction, repeated in (18a), we may contrast it with another existential construction with a more familiar noun incorporation profile, given in (18b). These constructions differ in the choice of embedding verb, the category of the incorporated constituent, and the syntactic relationship between the incorporant and the stranded MOD-marked element.¹⁵

(18) **Two existential constructions in Inuktitut**

- a. **anguti-mik tikit-tu-qaq-tuq**
man-MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
Speaker's translation: 'A man arrived.'
- b. **tikit-tur-mik anguti-taqaq-tuq**
arrive-PART-MOD man-exist-PART.3SG.S
Speaker's translation: 'There is a man who arrived.' (AB)

The two sentences are also not translated identically by speakers, which I take to further reflect their different underlying structures. The clause-incorporating existential in (18a) typically gets translated as a simple sentence consisting of a verb and its indefinite subject, while (18b) is typically translated as a 'there'-existential, with the participial clause serving as a relative clause modifying the indefinite nominal.¹⁶ Importantly, in contrast to (18b), the construction in (18a) will be argued to *not* involve relativization, despite the surface similarities with true relative clauses (§4.2).

These constructions also differ in the locus of the *pivot* of the existential construction, the nominal whose existence is under discussion: in (18a) it is the (standalone) embedded subject and in (18b) it is the incorporated object. That the subject in the former example is indeed the existential pivot is demonstrated by its sensitivity to the Definiteness Restriction (Milsark, 1974, et seq.). Proper names and pronouns are permitted only if interpreted as non-referential, (19a-b), and other definite expressions such as possessive DPs are disallowed entirely, (19c).¹⁷

(19) **Definiteness Effect on embedded subject**

- a. **Taiviti-mik tikit-tu-qaq-tuq**
David-MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
'A person whose name is David arrived.'
'David arrived.' (AB)
- b. **(pro) qai-ju-qa-qqau-nngit-tuq**
(3SG.MOD) come-PART-have-REC.PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
'No one came.'
'[3SG referent] didn't come.' (IQ)

¹⁵An additional existential construction is provided in (i) for completeness. Here, the suffix *-lik* is a nominal suffix that roughly has the meaning 'one that has'. I do not discuss this construction further due to paucity of data, but see Yuan 2018, pp. 238-240 on other constructions containing this suffix.

(i) **Existential construction with nominal suffix *-lik***

arnar-nik marruu-nik ani-ju-lik
woman-MOD.PL two-MOD.PL leave-PART-have.NMLZ
'Two women left.' (AB)

¹⁶That being said, this paper cannot provide a more precise semantic analysis of the clause-incorporating existential construction, since its focus is on its morphosyntactic properties.

¹⁷In the clause-incorporating existential, this restriction holds only in the pivot position; definite expressions are allowed in other positions (e.g., as embedded objects), despite also being within the scope of the verb *-qaq* 'have'. This can be seen in examples such as (22) and (23b).

- c. ***anaana-nga-nik** tikit-tu-qaq-tuq
 mother-POSS.3SG-MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 Intended: ‘Her mother arrived.’ (AB)

The existential verb *-qaq* ‘have’ is also used in possessive contexts, as in examples like (13a) in the previous section. The possessee incorporated into *-qaq* ‘have’ is likewise subject to the Definiteness Restriction. Note also that this restriction is not inherent to *all* nominals within the scope of an incorporating verb, as Inuktitut permits proper names and pronouns to undergo incorporation into other verbs, as already seen in (13). The Definiteness Restriction thus only affects certain nominals embedded under *-qaq* ‘have’.

As (20) shows, the embedded subject of the clause-incorporating existential may also be plural. However, the complex verb in these examples still bears 3SG matrix ϕ -agreement (note that the embedded participial morphology is ϕ -invariant as well). This follows broadly from the generalizations about the case and agreement system sketched in §2.1. For now, we may conclude that the embedded subject is indeed structurally low.

(20) **No ϕ -agreement with plural existential pivots**

- a. **arnar-nik** marruu-**nik** ani-ju-qaq-tuq
 woman-PL.MOD two-PL.MOD leave-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘Two women left.’ (AB)
- b. **Mittimataling-miu-nik** tikit-tu-qaq-tuq
 Mittimatalik-person.from-PL.MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘People from Mittimatalik (Pond Inlet) arrived.’ (AB)

Matrix ϕ -agreement instead indexes what I propose is a expletive subject. Although 3rd person pronouns in Inuktitut are null, the presence of an expletive subject may be detected by 3SG ϕ -agreement—whether subject agreement, as in the examples above, or object agreement in ECM constructions, as in (21).¹⁸ Notably, this ϕ -morphology cannot be analyzed as default agreement appearing in the absence of a goal (as in Preminger 2011, 2014): in Inuktitut such configurations are actually reflected by the loss of agreement morphology altogether, as independently shown in Yuan 2023.

(21) **Expletive subject of clause-incorporating existential under ECM**

- (*pro*) [(*pro*_{EXPL}) inung-mi=luunniit tiki-saali-ju-qa]-qu-nngit-**tara**
 (1SG.ERG) (3SG.ABS) person-MOD-NPI arrive-early-PART-have -want-NEG-1SG.S/3SG.O
 ‘I don’t want anyone to arrive early.’ (AB)

3.2 Internal structure of the embedded clause

While the examples provided so far have mostly featured embedded intransitive verbs, the data below demonstrate that the embedded verbs may also be logically transitive—though, crucially, the resulting constructions are obligatorily antipassive, yielding a MOD-MOD case frame. This generalization moreover extends beyond the simple monotransitives in (22a-b). In (22c), a causativized verb is antipassivized, resulting in MOD case assignment to the causee; in (22d), an affixal ECM verb is antipassivized, with the subject embedded under that verb now marked MOD. These data moreover illustrate the point from §2.1 that the language has several antipassive allomorphs, including a null variant, conditioned by the nature of the verb stem (e.g. Fortescue, 1996; Schmidt, 2003; Spreng, 2006, 2012).

¹⁸As discussed by Yuan (2018), the existence of expletives in Inuktitut is further evidenced by the fact that they may also be antipassivized under ECM.

(22) **Incorporated transitive participial clauses are antipassivized**

- a. nutaraar-nik **uqumiagar-mik** niri-Ø-ju-qa-lau-nngit-tuq
child-PL.MOD candy-MOD buy-AP-PART-have-PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
'No children bought candy.' (AB)
- b. anguti-mik **igalaar-mik** surak-si-ju-qaq-tuq
man-MOD window-MOD break-AP-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
'A man broke the window.' (AB)
- c. arnar-mik **pani-mi-nik** mumi-tit-si-ju-qaq-tuq
woman-MOD daughter-POSS.REFL-MOD dance-CAUS-AP-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
'A woman_i made her_i daughter dance.' (SN)
- d. (*pro*) **uvan-nik** kinguvar-nira-i-ju-qaq-tuq
(3SG.MOD) 1SG-MOD be.late-say-AP-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
'Someone said that I was late.' (AB)

It is also possible for the object of the embedded verb to be incorporated, as in (23). Although such objects are not overtly marked MOD (and there is no verbal antipassive morphology), incorporated nouns in Inuktitut are syntactically akin to antipassive objects, as briefly shown in §2.2 above.¹⁹ These data thus still adhere to the above generalization.

(23) **Embedded affixal verbs with nominal complements**

- a. anguti-mit **nunasiuti-taaq-tu-qa-lauq-tuq**
man-MOD car-get-PART-have-PST-PART.3SG.S
'A man bought a car.' (PG)
- b. (*pro*) **Jaani-siuq-tu-qa-qqau-juq**
(3SG.MOD) John-look.for-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
'Someone was looking for Jaani.' (PI)

The examples shown so far have confirmed that these incorporated constituents contain at least vP-level structure underneath the participial morphology. In fact, these elements also demonstrably contain higher projections such as TP and NegP. Though T⁰ is typically null in these constructions (for reasons to be further discussed in §4.1), the embedded element may sometimes bear overt tense morphology, (24a).²⁰ The embedded constituent may also contain sentential negation, (24b), which in Inuktitut heads its own projection above tense.²¹

(24) **Incorporated participial clauses may contain TP and NegP**

- a. arnar-mik **tiki-qqau-ju-qa-qqau-juq**
woman-MOD arrive-REC.PST-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
'A woman arrived (earlier today).' (AB)

¹⁹That being said, Yuan (2025), building on data introduced in Johns 2009 and Beach 2011, demonstrates that incorporated objects in Inuktitut may also behave like ABS objects of ergative constructions (co-occurring with object ϕ -morphology and ERG subjects), meaning that incorporation constructions alternate between antipassive and ergative, on par with other transitive verbs in the language. Thus, the generalization discussed here pertains only to the antipassive incorporation construction.

²⁰The double appearance of the REC.PST marker -*qqau* will be explained in §4.1.

²¹In examples that feature both overt tense and negation, as in (i), negation surfaces outside of tense:

(i) **T < Neg morpheme order**

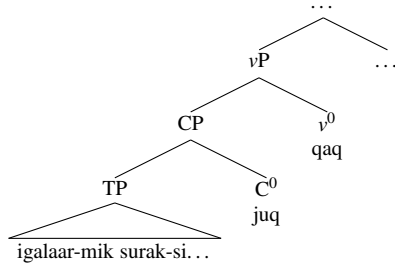
- atausi-ni=luunniit qai-ju-qa-lau-nngit-tuq
one-MOD=NPI come-PART-have-PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
'Not a single person came.' (IQ)

- b. inung-mit qai-**nngit**-tu-qaq-tuq
 person-MOD come-NEG-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘Someone didn’t come.’ (PG)

Recall from (14)-(15) in §2.2 that Inuktitut has ECM-like constructions involving the incorporation of TP clauses. As the clauses currently under discussion additionally contain participial morphology outside of TP and NegP, they must be even larger. Given that participial morphology otherwise encodes clause type in root clauses, we may infer that these incorporants are CPs. However, there is no ϕ -agreement morphology in the embedded clausal constituent, though we previously concluded that ϕ -agreement is part of the extended CP domain, located in a higher head as shown in (6). Although incorporated constituents usually surface without ϕ -morphology (as noted in §2.2 for nouns), I propose that its absence here is structural: the CP is missing its outermost AgrP superstructure. This will be further reinforced in §5.

The tree in (25), partially depicting (22b), illustrates the picture so far, though it omits the embedded subject, the existential pivot. I turn to the exact position of the pivot next.

(25) **Simplified structure of embedded clause in clause-incorporating existential (based on (22b))**



3.3 The existential pivot controls a clause-internal subject

The existential pivot’s syntactic position relative to the embedded participial clause is not immediately obvious, given that the clause is incorporated. The fact that the nominal exhibits the Definiteness Restriction has already been taken to indicate that it is within the scope of the matrix verb *-qaq* ‘have’. But where is it relative to the participial clause itself, which is also embedded under *-qaq* ‘have’?

Based on semantic and morphological diagnostics, I demonstrate that the nominal behaves as though it is simultaneously outside *and* inside of the embedded clause—which I reconcile in terms of *control*. This is an important conclusion: not only does it inform the structure of the complex constituent under *-qaq* ‘have’ (see below), but, foreshadowing the pseudorelative analysis of §4, it dovetails with the common treatment of pseudorelatives cross-linguistically as containing a controlled subject (e.g. Cinque 1992; Rafel 2000; Casalicchio 2014; Koopman and Sportiche 2014).

First, the *clause-external* position of the nominal is evidenced by NPI-licensing. As demonstrated by Bittner (1994) for Kalaallisut, and replicated for Inuktitut by Yuan (2018, 2021, 2022), the disjunctive clitic *=luunniit* ‘or’ is an NPI, as it is interpreted as a minimizer under clausemate negation (boxed in the examples below). As a baseline, the data in (26) show that NPI licensing is possible in ABS subject position, expected if negation heads a dedicated projection above TP and thus also above the subject. However, an NPI that is construed as the subject of an incorporated participial clause *cannot* be licensed by embedded negation, (27a), instead requiring matrix negation, (27b).

(26) **Licensing of subject NPI under negation**

- a. kina=**luunniit** saqi-lau-nngit-tuq
 who.ABS=or show.up-PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
 ‘Not a single person showed up.’ (AB; Yuan 2021, p. 163)

- b. atausi=**luunniit** inuk tavvunga-qu-ji-**nngit**-tuq Jaani-mik
 one.ABS=or person.ABS be.here-want-AP-NEG-PART.3SG.S Jaani-MOD
 ‘Not a single person wants Jaani to be here.’ (PG)

(27) **Pivot NPI only licensed by matrix negation**

- a. *ilinnarti-mik atausir-mig=**luunniit** saqi-**nngit**-tu-qa-lauq-tuq
 student-MOD one-MOD=or show.up-NEG-PART-have-PST-PART.3SG.S
 Intended: ‘Not a single student showed up.’ (AB)
- b. ilinnarti-mik atausir-mig=**luunniit** saqi-tu-qa-lau-**nngit**-tuq
 student-MOD one-MOD=or show.up-PART-have-PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
 ‘Not a single student showed up.’ (AB)

In the same vein, embedded (non-NPI) indefinite subjects are naturally interpreted by speakers as taking narrow scope under matrix negation but wide scope over embedded negation, as in (28) (see also (30) below). Together, (27)-(28) indicate that the existential pivot cannot be located inside the embedded incorporated clause, since it appears to not be c-commanded by embedded negation.

(28) **Scope of pivot relative to matrix vs. embedded negation**

- a. **pani-mik** anaana-mi-nik iqi-ti-ju-qa-lau-**nngit**-tuq
 daughter-MOD mother-POSS.REFL-MOD hug-AP-PART-have-PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
 ‘No daughter_i hugged her_i mother ($\neg > \exists$).’ (AB)
- b. **pani-mik** anaana-mi-nik iqi-ti-**nngit**-tu-qa-lauq-tuq
 daughter-MOD mother-POSS.REFL-MOD hug-AP-NEG-PART-have-PST-PART.3SG.S
 ‘One daughter_i didn’t hug her_i mother ($\exists > \neg$).’ (AB)

On the other hand, there are reasons to think that the existential pivot *is* inside of the embedded clause as well. UTAH is an immediate consideration (Chomsky 1981; Baker 1988): as the subject is interpreted as a thematic argument of the embedded verb, it should be first Merged within the extended verb phrase. Furthermore, (28) shows that the embedded subject may bind a reflexive possessor within a lower embedded argument (e.g., the object), as indicated by reflexive agreement on the latter. This reflexive is subject-oriented (e.g. Bittner, 1994; Manning, 1996), in that only external arguments may serve as antecedents. If subject-oriented binding is mediated through a reflexive variety of v^0 (or Voice⁰) that Agrees with both the antecedent and the reflexive (e.g. Labelle, 2008; Ahn, 2015; Ershova, 2023), this is more evidence that the antecedent is base-generated in its θ -position inside the embedded clause.²²

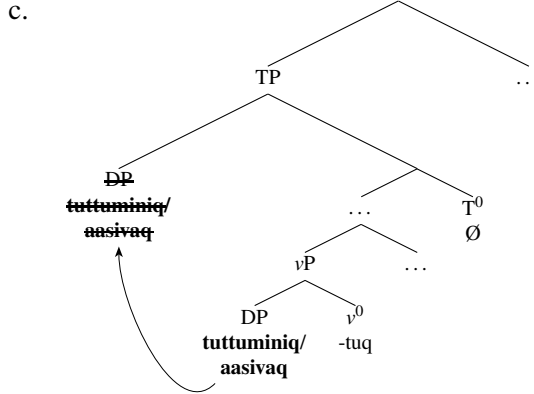
Finally, and most strikingly, the pivot may in certain cases appear *overtly* within the embedded clause. To appreciate this point, consider first the examples in (29). In (29a), we see that affixal verbs may be passivized, an observation first made by Johns (2009). As briefly alluded to in §2.2, Yuan (2025) argues that incorporated complements of such passivized affixal verbs truly undergo A-movement to a derived subject position (Spec-TP), given that this may arise in new binding relations, shown in (29b). She attributes the incorporated appearance of such nouns to an interaction between movement and the Stray Affix Filter (Lasnik, 1981, 1995, et seq.), which prevents morphologically bound elements from being realized without an overt host. As schematized in (29c), the affixal nature of the verb forces the lower copy of an incorporated passivized nominal to be spelled out. General considerations of economy of pronunciation then triggers deletion of the higher copy of

²²The binding data shown in (28) additionally rule out an alternative analysis presented by a reviewer, wherein the MOD-marked embedded nominal is adjoined to the participial clause rather than serving as an argument generated inside of it. We would not expect an adjunct to be able to bind a subject-oriented reflexive possessive. The facts presented in (29) below, which demonstrate that the pivot may surface overtly as an internal argument of the embedded verb, further rule out this analysis. The same reviewer also raises the possibility that the binder is actually the participial clause itself, assuming that it is nominalized (see fn. 7). This, is, however, syntactically implausible, given that there would be no c-command relationship between the two; the nominal that contains the possessive reflexive is an internal argument of the embedded verb contained within the clause.

movement in Spec-TP (e.g. Landau, 2006; van Urk, 2018; Davis et al., 2020).

(29) **Lower copy spell out of passivized subject**

- a. **tuttu-miniq-tuq-ta-u-juq**
 caribou-former-consume-PASS.PART-be-PART.3SG.S
 ‘The caribou meat is being eaten.’ (NB; Johns 2009, p. 195)
- b. **aasivar-tuq-ta-u-juq** **nuliaqta-mi-nut**
 spider-consume-PASS.PART-be-PART.3SG.S mate-POSS.REFL-ALLAT
 ‘The spider_i is being eaten by its_i mate.’ (AB; Yuan 2025, p. 527)



With this analysis in mind, let us turn to (30). Here, a passivized internal argument is incorporated into an affixal verb, which is, in turn, contained within an incorporated participial clause. Crucially, the passivized nominal is the pivot of the resulting clause-incorporating existential construction. Notice, also, that (30a-b) differ in the locus of negation (matrix vs. embedded), which affects the interpretation of the embedded passivized subject. In line with the generalizations formed with (27) and (28), the nominal still outscores embedded negation, even though it is realized as incorporated into the embedded affixal verb. Unsurprisingly, however, it remains within the scope of matrix negation. These constructions, I argue, follow the same derivation as in (29c): morphological well-formedness conditions force the spell-out of the existential pivot as the object of the affixal verb, even though it has been passivized to subject position.

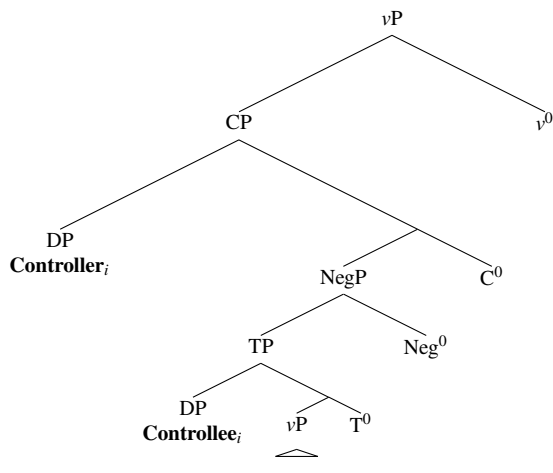
(30) **Clause-internal spell out of subject of clause-incorporating existential**

- a. [**sivalaar-tuq-ta-u-ju**]-qa-qqau-**nngit**-tuq
 cookie-consume-PASS.PART-be-PART -have-REC.PST-NEG-PART.3SG.S
 ‘No cookies were eaten.’ (AB)
 Speaker’s comment: “This means all the cookies were not eaten.” ($\neg > \exists$)
- b. [**sivalaar-tuq-ta-u-nngit**-tu]-qa-qqau-juq
 cookie-consume-PASS.PART-be-NEG-PART -have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A cookie wasn’t eaten.’ (AB)
 Speaker’s comment: “One [cookie] was left over.” ($\exists > \neg$)

This, again, reifies the impression that the subject, the existential pivot, is both external and internal to the embedded clause. I suggest that this is most straightforwardly captured by a *control structure*, in that this nominal is co-indexed with a lower element in the embedded subject position. This is schematized in (31), which (foreshadowing §4) depicts the existential pivot as the specifier of embedded C⁰.²³

²³A reviewer wonders whether the same facts could be captured under an A-movement analysis, so that the overt nominal and its embedded gap are copies of an A-chain. As mentioned below, this cannot be totally ruled out, especially given movement-based

(31) **Control structure in clause-incorporating existential**



Importantly, while analyses of control classically invoke a null PRO, Inuktitut requires a different representation, since the embedded controlled subject may be forced to surface overtly. The data in (30) constitute a *backward control* pattern, in that the controllee rather than the controller is overt (e.g. Polinsky and Potsdam, 2002; Potsdam, 2009; Haddad, 2009; Pietraszko, 2021). In certain languages, such as Telugu, backward control may co-exist with the more familiar forward control pattern, (32). This seems to be the case in Inuktitut, as well, though the two patterns are not optional as they seem to be in Telugu: Inuktitut mostly displays forward control, with backward control emerging only to meet the morphological requirements of affixal verbs.

(32) **Forward and backward control in Telugu**

- a. **Kumaar_i** [Δ_i aakali wees-i] saandwic tinnaa-Du
Kumar.NOM hunger.NOM fall-CNP sandwich ate-3M.S
'Having got hungry, Kumar ate a sandwich.'
- b. Δ_i [**Kumaar-ki_i** aakali wees-i] saandwic tinnaa-Du
Kumar-DAT hunger.NOM fall-CNP sandwich ate-3M.S
'Having got hungry, Kumar ate a sandwich.' (Haddad, 2009, p. 70)

There are multiple different analyses of backward control. The most prominent analysis invokes A-movement (Hornstein, 1999), meaning that the controllee raises from inside the embedded clause into the higher clause, followed by lower copy spell-out and concomitant higher copy deletion (see also Polinsky and Potsdam 2002; Boeckx et al. 2008; Fukuda 2008; Potsdam 2009; Haddad 2009). This seems largely compatible with the Inuktitut facts shown here and would be a simple extension of Yuan's (2025) analysis of the Stray Affix Filter regulating movement chain resolution in incorporation contexts.²⁴

* * * *

To summarize this section, we have seen that the clause-incorporating existential construction consists of an embedded participial clause and a clause-external nominal that serves as the existential pivot. The embedded

analyses of backward control. Under an A-movement analysis, however, it may be difficult to derive the obligatory wide scope reading seen in examples like (28), which show that reconstruction under embedded negation is not possible.

²⁴It may also be possible to derive the backward control pattern without movement, if we assume that controlled PRO may be overt (e.g. Lee, 2003; Ostrove, 2026) and that the above morphological conditions on chain resolution also determine when deletion under identity is possible (e.g. Saab, 2022). What is not compatible with the Inuktitut facts, however, is a non-movement account of backward control that proposes a single nominal in the embedded clause related to the matrix clause by agreement (e.g. Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou, 2019; Pietraszko, 2021). Such an analysis cannot account for the morphological underpinnings of nominal spell-out vs. deletion in Inuktitut.

clause is built up to the (minimal) CP layer but no further. The existential pivot is related to the embedded subject position via control, explaining why it behaves as if it is both external and internal to the clause. The next section develops these conclusions further.

4 A pseudorelative analysis of incorporated participial clauses

Building on the above findings, I now demonstrate that the existential pivot and the embedded clause form a *pseudorelative* CP (Kayne, 1975; Radford, 1977; Cinque, 1992, 1995, a.m.o.), meaning that they comprise the subject and (clause-sized) predicate of a small clause. Like other pseudorelatives cross-linguistically, the subject is located at the edge of the clause and is tied to the embedded subject position via control.

4.1 Properties of pseudorelatives

The vast majority of the existing research on pseudorelatives has focused on complements of perception verbs in mostly European languages,²⁵ such as Italian (Cinque, 1992, 1995; Moulton and Grillo, 2016), French (Kayne, 1975; Koopman and Sportiche, 2014), Portuguese (Brito, 1995; Costa et al., 2016), Greek (Angelopoulos, 2015), and Spanish (Herbeck, 2020; Aguilar and Grillo, 2021). As shown in (33), both pseudorelatives and subject relative clauses descriptively consist of a subject preceding a clause containing a subject gap. Moreover, they bear surface-identical clausal morphology, such as the complementizer *che*.

(33) Pseudorelative vs. subject relative clause in Italian

- a. Ho visto **Gianni**_i che ___i correva
I.have seen Gianni that run.IMPF
'I saw John run/running.'
- b. Vedo **la ragazza**_i che ___i correva
I.see.PRES the girl that run.IMPF
'I see the girl that was running.' (Moulton and Grillo, 2016, pp. 1-2)

However, pseudorelatives and subject relatives are underlyingly distinct constructions, as diagnosable by a constellation of syntactic properties that hold only in the former but not the latter construction. A (non-exhaustive) list of general properties of pseudorelatives is presented below.²⁶ As we will see below, these are also properties of the clause-incorporating existential in Inuktitut. I will also show in §4.3 that pseudorelative clauses in Inuktitut are morphosyntactically distinguishable from genuine relative clauses in the language.

- The pseudorelative does not denote an individual, but rather a situation

²⁵That being said, some authors have also observed that pseudorelatives are found in existential contexts (e.g. Cinque, 1992; Angelopoulos, 2015). Below is an example from Greek. However, as these constructions are quite underanalyzed compared to their perception verb complement counterparts, it is difficult to systematically compare them with the clause-incorporating existential constructions in Inuktitut.

(i) Existential pseudorelative in Greek

Iparchun anthropi [pu mas akun] afti ti stigmī
there.are people that us hear this the moment
'There are people hearing us now.' (Angelopoulos, 2015, p. 11)

²⁶An additional property is that the pseudorelative subject may be a proper name or pronoun, while the head of a (restrictive) subject relative cannot. However, this comparison cannot be applied to Inuktitut. First, recall that the clause incorporation existential construction exhibits the Definiteness Restriction, so such nominals are ruled out to begin with. Second, Compton (2012) argues that all relative clauses in Inuktitut are non-restrictive in nature, meaning that they may in fact be headed by proper names and pronouns.

- The gap in the pseudorelative clause is obligatorily in subject position, reflecting a control structure²⁷
- The pseudorelative clause is tense-deficient and must match the tense of the matrix clause
- The case of the subject is determined by the syntactic position of the overall pseudorelative structure

The first two properties listed above have already been established in the paper. That clause-incorporating existentials denote a situation was already indicated in §3.1; recall that such constructions are translated by speakers as full sentences with indefinite subjects. We also independently arrived at the control analysis in §3.3. In addition to the NPI-licensing and scope facts discussed therein, it was shown that the pivot may be construed as the subject of an intransitive, (antipassive) transitive, or passive verb, suggesting a subject-only gap in the embedded clause that is typical of control. The example in (34) below confirms this restriction: the pivot may not be construed as a transitive object.

(34) **No object gap in pseudorelative clause**

**sivalaar-mik* niri-ja-qaq-tuq
 cookie-MOD eat-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 Intended: ‘There is a cookie eaten.’ (AB)
 (cf. *sivalaaq niri-janga* ‘S/he ate the cookie.’)

The third property, concerning tense-deficiency, is consistent with the general picture of pseudorelatives cross-linguistically: although pseudorelative clauses may contain tense morphology, the tense feature must be anaphoric to that of the matrix clause (e.g. Rafel, 2000; Casalicchio, 2014; Casalicchio and Herbeck, 2024). The incorporated clause in Inuktitut turns out to display a similar restriction. Although the example in (35a) was originally introduced in (24a) to illustrate that the embedded constituent contains a TP, the overt tense morphology in the embedded clause does not appear to be semantically contentful. In fact, in most examples of the clause-incorporating existential provided in this paper, there is no overt tense morphology in the embedded clause at all; this is further illustrated in (35b), which forms a minimal pair with (35a).

(35) **Embedded tense is semantically vacuous**

- arnar-mik* tiki-qqau-ju-qa-qqau-juq
 woman-MOD arrive-REC.PST-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A woman arrived (earlier today).’ (AB)
- arnar-mik* tikit-Ø-tu-qa-qqau-juq
 woman-MOD arrive-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A woman arrived (earlier today).’ (AB)

Moreover, as shown in (36), genuine tense mismatches do not seem to be permitted between the two clauses.²⁸

²⁷ According to Aldama García (2018), however, some languages permit both subject and object gaps in pseudorelatives. This generalization thus only holds for the languages (including, I argue, Inuktitut) with subject-only gaps. Moreover, even for subject-only gaps, the control analysis is dominant (e.g. Cinque, 1995; Rafel, 2000; Casalicchio, 2014; Moulton and Grillo, 2015, 2016) but not universal; see Angelopoulos 2015 and Herbeck 2020 for alternative approaches.

²⁸ A reviewer wonders whether the badness of (36) may be due to pragmatic interference given that both tenses are past, and raises the possibility that a constructed sentence like (i) may fare better given a context that felicitously licenses it. I leave this here as an important question for future research. The present analysis predicts that a sentence such as (i) should remain ill-formed no matter the context.

(i) **Hypothetical clause-incorporating existential with tense mismatches**

arnar-mik qai-niaq-tu-qa-qqau-juq
 woman-MOD come-NR.FUT-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
 Intended: ‘There was a woman who will come later.’ (constructed)

Thus, putting (35) and (36) together, I conclude that the embedded clause does not contain independent tense, and that embedded T^0 is temporally determined by matrix T^0 .

(36) **No independent tense in the embedded clause**

*arnar-mik tiki-lauq-tu-qa-qqau-juq
 woman-MOD arrive-PST-PART-have-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S
 Intended possible translations: ‘A woman arrived (earlier today)’ or ‘There was (earlier today) a woman who had arrived in the past.’ (AB)

As a possible account of the tense-matching pattern in (35a), I suggest that a matrix and embedded T^0 may enter into a syntactic dependency due to the featural underspecification of embedded T^0 , along the lines of existing treatments of sequence of tense (e.g. Zeijlstra, 2012) and voice restructuring (e.g. Wurmbrand and Shimamura, 2017). I also assume that this process is optional, perhaps even dispreferred, given that embedded T^0 is usually null, as in (35b). A more thorough investigation of matrix and embedded tense in Inuktitut is outside of the purview of this paper, but the idea developed here is broadly compatible with Hayashi 2011, the only systematic investigation of independent and dependent tense in Inuktitut. The broader point here is that tense-deficiency is another property of pseudorelatives that is borne out in the clause-incorporating existential in Inuktitut.

The tense-deficient nature of these clauses is moreover not a general property of all incorporated clauses in Inuktitut. We have seen in earlier examples such as (14) (from §2.2) that embedded TPs under affixal ECM verbs may exhibit tense mismatches with the matrix clause. This contrast additionally reveals that the tense-deficient nature of Inuktitut pseudorelative CPs is not attributable to independent factors such as being structurally truncated, given that the aforementioned tensed embedded TPs are even smaller.

Finally, the pseudorelative subject receives the case that would be expected based on the syntactic position of the entire pseudorelative constituent. The Italian examples in (37) first provide a point of comparison, demonstrating that whether the subject is ACC or NOM corresponds to whether the pseudorelative is in matrix object or subject position. This also reveals that the subject of the pseudorelative is accessible to morphosyntactic processes such as case assignment arising from the matrix clause.

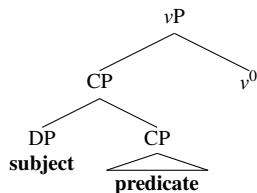
(37) **Case of subject determined by locus of pseudorelative**

- a. Ha visto [**me** che fumavo per strada]
 He.has seen me.ACC that smoke.IMP in street
 ‘He saw me smoking in the street.’
- b. [**Io** che fumo per strada] è uno spettacolo che non raccomando
 I.NOM that smoke.PRES in street is a sight that not recommend.1SG
 ‘Me smoking in the street is a sight I cannot recommend.’ (Moulton and Grillo, 2016, p. 11)

In the clause-incorporating existential in Inuktitut, we have already seen that the pseudorelative subject is necessarily MOD. As mentioned in §2.1 (and further developed in §5 below), this too is due to its syntactic position: its MOD case arises from the pseudorelative constituent’s position internal to the matrix vP.

Thus, pseudorelative clauses in Inuktitut display several properties that also hold of pseudorelatives in better-studied languages such as Italian. As discussed above, the literature generally agrees that the pseudorelative CP is a predicate of a small clause, whose subject is the nominal related to the CP-internal gap via control. Applying this to Inuktitut, we arrive at the structure in (38). Note that I assume that the small clause subject may Merge directly with the CP predicate as its specifier, following Matushansky 2019 on small clause structures more generally, though the data shown here are also compatible with a mediating PredP projection (e.g. Bowers, 1993, 2001; den Dikken, 2006). I additionally suggest that Merging the subject at the edge of the small clause is what permits it to be visible to matrix case assignment, resulting in MOD case.

(38) **Small clause analysis of Inuktitut pseudorelative**



The small clause analysis advocated for here is similar to other accounts of existentials in which the pivot is the subject of a small clause (e.g. McCloskey, 2014; Irwin, 2018). The relevant point of divergence is that the small clause predicate in Inuktitut is specifically a CP.

4.2 Comparing pseudorelative constructions in Inuktitut

It is worth also briefly comparing Inuktitut incorporated pseudorelative CPs to complements of perception verbs, which may be plausibly analyzed as pseudorelative CPs as well. Because this paper focuses on the clause-incorporating existential construction, the conclusions in this section are tentative, pending further research into complements of perception verbs in Inuktitut. Still, it is promising that, given the available data, the latter constructions appear to also display the cross-linguistically stable properties listed above, as well as the Inuktitut-internal properties established for incorporated pseudorelative CPs.

In (39), we see that complements of perception verbs are also participial clauses that lack ϕ -agreement with the subject. Therefore, we may conclude that they too are built up to the initial CP layer but no further.²⁹ Notice, also, that these standalone clauses bear the same MOD case morphology as their subjects (which I attribute to case concord). Recall from §2.2 that incorporated elements in Inuktitut generally do not overtly surface with case, even though there is evidence that they are assigned case syntactically. In light of this, it is unsurprising that pseudorelative clauses bear overt case when they are not incorporated.

(39) **Perception verb complement clauses are pseudorelative CPs**

- a. Kiuru tusaa-juma-juq [uvan-**nik** inngiq-**tur**-**mik**]
 Carol.ABS hear-want-PART.3SG.S 1SG-MOD sing-PART-MOD
 ‘Carol wants to hear me sing.’ (AB)
 (cf. *uvanga inngiq-tunga* ‘I am singing.’)
- b. Kiuru tusaa-juma-juq [ilitsi-**nik** inngiq-**tur**-**mik**]
 Carol.ABS hear-want-PART.3SG.S 2PL-MOD sing-PART-MOD
 ‘Carol wants to hear you (pl.) sing.’ (AB)
 (cf. *ilitsi inngiq-tusi* ‘You (pl.) are singing.’)

Moreover, in all examples of this construction elicited so far, the embedded verb is either intransitive or antipassive; this is consistent with the subject control analysis of pseudorelative clauses. The data in (40) moreover indicate that the tense matching effects seen above hold for perception verb complements as well, suggesting that they are also tense-deficient.³⁰

²⁹In addition, pseudorelative complements of perception verbs are canonically taken to encode direct (as opposed to indirect) perception. The idea that these are truncated CPs in Inuktitut dovetails with a similar finding by Grishin (to appear) that direct perception complement clauses are smaller-sized CPs than epistemic complement and root declarative clauses.

³⁰Though see fn. 28 on the potential caveat that the ill-formedness of the tense mismatch in (40b) could be due to pragmatic reasons. A reviewer also points out that one of the intended English translations of (40b), ‘I saw Tommy who slept yesterday’ is odd to begin with. However, the point here is that the Inuktitut string in (40b) was judged as ungrammatical regardless of how its translation—in contrast to (40a).

(40) **Perception verb complement clauses are tense deficient**

- a. taku-**qqau**-jara [Taami sini-**qqau**-juq]
 see-REC.PST-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O Tommy.ABS sleep-REC.PST-PART.ABS
 ‘I saw Tommy sleeping (earlier today).’ (AB)
- b. *taku-**qqau**-jara [Taami sini-**lauq**-tuq]
 see-REC.PST-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O Tommy.ABS sleep-PST-PART.ABS
 Intended possible translations: ‘(Earlier today) I saw Tommy sleeping’ or ‘(Earlier today) I saw Tommy who slept (yesterday).’ (AB)

Lastly, notice that in (40a) the subject and pseudorelative CP are ABS as opposed to MOD, as seen in previous examples. A clearer minimal pair illustrating the availability of both cases is given in (41).

(41) **Subjects of perception verb pseudorelatives may be MOD or ABS**

- a. tautu-qqau-nngit-tunga [Kiuru-**mik** inngiq-tur-**mik**]
 look.at-REC.PST-NEG-PART.1SG.S Carol-MOD sing-PART-MOD
 ‘I didn’t look at Carol singing.’ (AB)
- b. tautu-qqau-nngit-**tara** [**Kiuru** inngiq-**tuq**]
 look.at-REC.PST-NEG-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O Carol.ABS sing-PART.ABS
 ‘I didn’t look at Carol singing.’ (AB)

These examples provide further evidence that the case of the pseudorelative subject correlates with certain properties of the matrix clause: whether it is ABS or MOD correlates with the presence or absence of matrix ϕ -agreement. In §5 below, I analyze this in terms of the nominal’s (in)accessibility to a ϕ -probe in the matrix clausal periphery. In contrast, this alternation is not available in the clause-incorporating existential construction, since the pseudorelative constituent is necessarily trapped under the existential verb -*qaq* ‘have’ and is thus too low to participate in dependencies stemming from the matrix clause.

4.3 Distinguishing pseudorelatives and true relative clauses

Before concluding this section, I also briefly demonstrate that the constructions I have analyzed as pseudorelative CPs are indeed syntactically distinct from true relative clauses, despite surface appearances. In Inuktitut (as well as in other Inuit languages), relative clauses also contain participial morphology and bear the same case as the nominals they modify, as shown in (42).³¹

(42) **Relative clauses in Inuktitut**

- a. **anguti** [_{RC} nanur-mik kapi-si-juq] ani-juq
 man.ABS polar.bear-MOD stab-AP-PART.3SG.S leave-PART.3SG.S
 ‘The man who stabbed the polar bear went out.’ (SB; Johns 2007a)
- b. Miali kapi-si-juq nanur-**mit** [_{RC} Jaani-up taku-janga]-**nit**
 Miali.ABS stab-AP-PART.3SG.S polar.bear-MOD Jaani-ERG see-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O-MOD
 ‘Mary stabs the polar bear that John saw.’ (SB; Yuan 2013, p. 63)

An initial contrast concerns the observation that relative clauses are not truncated CPs. Whereas we have taken pseudorelative clauses to lack the higher CP-level projection associated with ϕ -agreement, the example in (42b) demonstrates that embedded verbs of relative clauses do bear ϕ -agreement.

³¹Here, I abstract away from the possibility, as pursued by Compton 2012, that relative clauses are actually nominal in nature. Specifically, Compton (2012) takes nominals and their relative clause modifiers to involve two DPs in apposition, meaning that one DP is adjoined to the other; this structure will be adopted in §6. If both relative CPs and pseudorelative CPs are subsequently nominalized, this would still be largely compatible with the rest of the paper. See also fn. 7 for relevant discussion.

These clauses also differ in the nature of the clause-internal gap. The Inuit languages are syntactically ergative, so only ABS arguments may be relativized (e.g. Creider, 1978; Johns, 1992; Bittner and Hale, 1996a; Murasugi, 1997). Importantly, what this means is that the gap of a relative clause may either be the subject of an intransitive or antipassive verb, as in (42a), or the object of a transitive verb, as in (42b). However, recall from §4.1 above that the incorporated CP of the clause-incorporating existential may only contain a subject gap. This again shows that the latter is not a relative clause.

Third, whereas pseudorelative CPs appear to be tense-deficient, genuine relative clauses are not. Relative clauses may bear their own overt tense, distinct from matrix tense, (43):

(43) **Relative clauses are not tense-deficient**

- a. anguti [RC Jaani taku-**lauq**-tanga sivataaviulauqtu-mik]
 man.ABS Jaani.ABS see-PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O last.week-MOD
 tavva-u-liq-tuq
 there-be-PROG-PART.3SG.S
 ‘The man that Jaani saw last week is right there.’ (PG)
- b. pi-juma-junga [RC niri-**qqau**-jang]-nit ajji-nga-nit
 PROFORM-want-PART.1SG.S eat-REC.PST-PART.2SG.S/3SG.O-MOD image-POSS.3SG-MOD
 ‘I want to get the same thing you ate (earlier).’ (PI)

A final difference pertains to the incorporation patterns that arise when these constituents are embedded under an affixal verb. The examples first introduced in (18) are repeated as (44) below; we may now analyze the participial clause in (44a) as a pseudorelative clause and its counterpart in (44b) as a relative clause. In (44a), the clause is incorporated and the nominal is stranded; in (44b), the opposite obtains.

(44) **Pseudorelative vs. relative clause in incorporation constructions**

- a. **anguti-mik tikit-tu-qaq**-tuq
 man-MOD arrive-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 Speaker’s translation: ‘A man arrived.’ (AB)
- b. **tikit-tur-mik anguti-taqaq**-tuq
 arrive-PART-MOD man-exist-PART.3SG.S
 Speaker’s translation: ‘There is a man who arrived.’ (AB)

This asymmetry is shown again in the minimal pair in (45), featuring *-qaq* ‘have’ in both examples. Incorporating a clause vs. a nominal correlates with an existential vs. possessive reading arising.

(45) **No incorporation of relative clauses**

- a. nunasiuti-mik **aupak-tu-qaq**-tuq
 car-MOD red-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘There is a red car.’ (AB)
Unavailable: ‘(S)he has a car that is red.’
- b. **aupak-tu-mik nunasiuti-qaq**-tuq
 red-PART-MOD car-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘(S)he has a car that is red.’ (AB)
Unavailable: ‘There is a red car.’

The contrast in (45), in particular, will be further explored in §6 when we discuss the morphosyntax of incorporation in more detail. For now, it once again confirms that the embedded CP of the clause-incorporating existential construction is not a true relative clause.

I have argued that the clause-incorporating existential contains a pseudorelative structure, in that the embedded subject and the incorporated clause are the subject and CP predicate of a small clause. This analysis captures several interlocking properties of these clauses, as they turn out to parallel those of pseudorelative constructions in better-studied languages such as Italian, as well as other constructions analyzable as pseudorelatives in Inuktitut. Additionally, the small clause structure allows us to locate the embedded subject as the specifier of the clausal predicate. In §5 below, we will see how this analysis informs our understanding of the case and agreement system of Inuktitut.

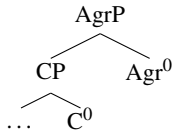
5 Case assignment in incorporated pseudorelative clauses

Having developed our pseudorelative analysis of the clause-incorporating existential construction, we may now return to the case and agreement system in Inuktitut. The generalizations first introduced in §2.1 are repeated below as (46):

- (46) **Case and agreement in Inuktitut are tied to the extended CP domain**
- a. ERG and ABS cases (indirectly) reflect successful Agree with ϕ -probes located in the extended CP domain, while MOD case reflects no such ϕ -Agree relations
 - b. No other functional heads (e.g., located in the TP- and vP-domains) are implicated in case assignment and ϕ -agreement

Additionally, in §2.1 we established the clausal periphery repeated in (47). Putting the ideas in (46) and (47) together, the absence of ERG and ABS case in embedded incorporated clauses follows from the truncated (i.e., AgrP-less) status of pseudorelative CPs.

- (47) **Extended CP domain in Inuktitut**



This analysis thus attributes the lack of ϕ -agreement morphology on these clauses to missing syntactic structure. Recall from §2.2, however, that inflectional morphology is often missing on incorporated constituents in Inuit, as most readily seen with incorporated plural nouns, and that this may also be explained in purely morphological terms (e.g. Sadock, 1985, 1991; Yuan, 2025); this raises the possibility that embedded incorporated clauses are actually non-reduced AgrPs that simply cannot morphologically express the ϕ -agreement on Agr⁰. However, only a syntactic account based on structural truncation correctly captures the distinct case patterns on the nominals inside such clauses. In contrast, an account based solely on morphological subcategorization does not explain this correlation, making no predictions about nominal case either way.³²

5.1 Agreement and case at the extended clausal periphery

As alluded to in §2.1, the inability for nominals generated inside incorporated CPs to be assigned ERG or ABS case rules out analyses that tie these cases to lower domains such as vP or TP.³³ This is regardless of whether

³²This, in turn, suggests that we should differentiate between two types of ϕ -less incorporants in Inuktitut: ones that genuinely lack the syntactic structure associated with ϕ -morphology and ones that simply cannot expone them morphologically.

³³This discussion focuses just on subjects of incorporated pseudorelative CPs for now; recall from (40a) in §4.2 above that subjects of standalone pseudorelative CPs may alternate between MOD and ABS. The availability of ABS case on the latter will be explained later in this section.

one pursues a functional head approach or a dependent (configurational) approach to case assignment. For instance, ERG case is commonly argued to be assigned by v^0 (e.g. Woolford, 2006; Aldridge, 2008; Legate, 2008; Spreng, 2012; Coon et al., 2021; Tollan and Massam, 2022; Poole, 2024; Clem and Deal, 2026), by T^0 (e.g. Bobaljik, 1993; Rezac et al., 2014), or through a combination of both heads (e.g. Deal, 2010; Clem, 2019; Ganenkov, 2022); this literature also often takes ABS to be assigned by v^0 or T^0 . Under dependent case approaches, too, ERG and ABS are often modeled as assigned within the TP domain (e.g. Marantz, 1991; Baker, 2014, 2015; Baker and Bobaljik, 2017). But we have already seen that vP - and TP-level projections are present within the clause-incorporating existential construction, yet the embedded nominals may only surface as MOD.

Similarly, we may not attribute the absence of ERG and ABS to the tense-deficient nature of embedded T^0 , in line with the often-observed unavailability of NOM case on subjects of non-finite clauses (e.g. Chomsky and Lasnik, 1993; Chomsky, 2000). To show why this is not viable for Inuktitut, I compare incorporated pseudorelative clauses with so-called ‘contemporative’ embedded clauses, in which embedded T^0 is likewise interpretively dependent on matrix tense (e.g. Johns and Smallwood, 1999; Hayashi, 2011). Crucially, unlike incorporated pseudorelative clauses, contemporative clauses do permit ERG and ABS arguments, (48). This demonstrates that the assignment of these cases is not tied to any aspect of T^0 .

(48) **ERG and ABS arguments available in other dependent tense contexts**

- a. [Alana-up **ujagak** atja-tlugu] ani-vuk
Alana-ERG rock.ABS carry-CTMP.3SG.S go.out-IND.3SG.S
‘While Alana was carrying the rock, she went out.’ (L; Johns and Smallwood 1999, p. 162)
- b. Jaani tuni-si-juq titirauti-mik Miali-mut [**inuit**
Jaani.ABS give-AP-PART.3SG.S pen-MOD Miali-ALLAT person.PL.ABS
utiqti-si-tillugit]
return-AP-CTMP.3PL.S
‘Jaani gave his pen to Miali, but the people returned it.’ (PG)

However, notice that contemporative clauses encode ϕ -morphology. The relevant difference between contemporative and pseudorelative clauses is, again, that the former are full clauses built up to AgrP while the latter are not.

This correlation between the presence of AgrP and the assignment of ERG and ABS case is compatible with multiple theories of case. For instance, we could posit that ERG and ABS cases are directly assigned by Agr⁰, meaning that this head is responsible for both ϕ -agreement and case assignment (e.g. Compton, 2018; Carrier, 2020).³⁴ Alternatively, we could pursue a slightly more complex analysis, as developed by Yuan (2022), in which the connection between ϕ -agreement and case assignment is more indirect. Below, I broadly follow Yuan’s account, since it may be readily extended to capture obligatory MOD case assignment to subjects and objects in the clause-incorporating existential.

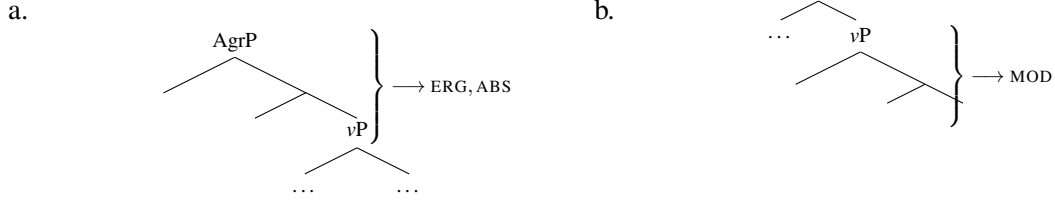
The analysis of Yuan (2022) is couched in Dependent Case Theory (e.g. Marantz, 1991; Baker, 2015), which takes case rules to apply based on c-command relations between nominals.³⁵ Yuan posits two distinct domains

³⁴Similarly, Carrier and Compton (2025) tie at least ABS case to illocutionary force, restricting it to root clauses. I set this analysis aside here since it assumes the nominalization-based analysis discussed in fn. 7.

³⁵For Yuan (2022), case is assigned via configurational rules instead of Agreeing heads; specifically, Yuan takes dependent ERG case to be assigned to the *lower* of two vP -external DPs, so this approach requires that the transitive (ABS) object raise above the subject. I abstract away from this particular configuration here, since what matters more for our purposes is the bifurcation of the clause into two distinct case assignment domains. More recently, however, Poole (2024) and Clem and Deal (2026) have developed Agree-based approaches to dependent case, wherein a single probe may Agree with multiple DPs to assign case: unmarked case and dependent case are assigned via first- and second-cycle Agree, respectively. I believe that this would work for Inuktitut as well, so long as the Agreeing probe remains in the extended CP-domain, where it c-commands both arguments (in contrast, these both Poole and Clem and Deal take the relevant probe to be located in v^0). This modification would be a way of reconciling previous analyses of Inuktitut case as assigned by CP-level heads (Compton, 2018; Carrier, 2020; Carrier and Compton, 2025) with the particular implementation of dependent ERG case assignment of Yuan (2022).

of case assignment, bifurcated by ν P. Within the higher domain, ERG is a dependent case whose assignment is contingent on the presence of two case-requiring DPs; ABS is an unmarked case realized on the DP that does not receive dependent case. MOD is also analyzed as an unmarked case, except it is assigned in the ν P-internal domain. The case domains for ERG, ABS, and MOD are schematized in (49). Note that I specifically depict the ν P-external domain in (49a) as an AgrP, which means that the dependent case rules responsible for ERG and ABS cannot apply in reduced clauses without this projection. This distinction is not articulated in Yuan 2022, which does not consider reduced clauses, but I demonstrate below that it accounts for the case properties of pseudorelative CPs.

(49) **Domain-sensitive ERG, ABS, and MOD case assignment**



To account for the fact that the arguments that are assigned ERG and ABS are the same ones indexed by clause-peripheral ϕ -agreement, Yuan (2022) proposes that the probe responsible for ϕ -agreement also triggers movement, resulting in the relevant DPs landing in the ν P-external domain (see also Compton 2018 and Mikkelsen et al. 2026 for other versions of this general idea). In contrast, arguments that are not indexed by ϕ -agreement remain within the ν P and are accordingly assigned MOD case. Altogether, this system derives the case patterns found in non-reduced clauses. Subjects are ERG if they co-occur with a high ABS object and are ABS otherwise; antipassive objects, which remain low, are MOD.

Additionally, this analysis predicts that multiple nominals may be assigned MOD case if they all remain within the ν P, since the ν P-internal domain does not have any other case assignment rules. This prediction is borne out, as shown by examples like (9b), repeated in (50) below. In this construction, which features four arguments in total, the two DPs not assigned ERG and ABS or indexed by ϕ -agreement surface with MOD case.

(50) **Multiple MOD arguments in triple object constructions**

(*pro*) Jaani qiturnga-**nik** tuni-si-qu-jara mamaq-tu-**nik**
 (1SG.ERG) Jaani.ABS offspring-PL.MOD give-AP-want-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O tasty-PART-PL.MOD
 ‘I want Jaani to give the children candy (lit. tasty things).’ (IG)

With the above system of case assignment in place, we may now turn to case assignment within incorporated pseudorelative clauses.

5.2 Case assignment inside reduced embedded clauses

As shown above, subjects and objects within incorporated pseudorelative clauses are obligatorily MOD, rather than ERG and ABS. This follows straightforwardly from the present account: because incorporated pseudorelative clauses are reduced CPs rather than full AgrPs, the dependent case rules for ERG and ABS case assignment are not met. However, because these clauses are embedded under the affixal verb *-qaq* ‘have’, the nominals associated with such clauses are considered internal to the ν P and are assigned MOD case accordingly. This is illustrated in (51).

(51) **Deriving obligatorily MOD embedded arguments**

a. [_{CP} anguti-**mik** igalaar-**mik** surak-si-ju]-qaq-tuq
 man-MOD window-MOD break-AP-PART -have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A man broke the window.’

```

graph TD
    Root[ ] --- vP[vP]
    Root --- Ellipsis1[...]
    vP --- CP[CP]
    vP --- v0[v^0]
    v0 --- have[have]
    CP --- DP[DP]
    DP --- man_mod["man-mod"]
    CP --- TP[TP]
    TP --- Triangle1[ ]
    Triangle1 --- window_mod["window-mod"]
    Triangle1 --- break_AP["break-AP-..."]
    Triangle1 --- Empty1[ ]
    TP --- C0[C^0]
    C0 --- PART[PART]
  
```

The idea that *-qaq* ‘have’ is a specifier-less v^0 is not simply a stipulation, but is evidenced by its incorporation profile, as most readily seen by contrasting it with other affixal verbs in the language. As highlighted by Yuan (2025) (building on Johns 2007b and Beach 2011), many affixal verbs in Inuktitut permit their incorporated objects to alternate between MOD and ABS, (52), meaning that the resulting constructions do not necessarily appear as morphosyntactically intransitive or antipassive. That the incorporant in (52b) is ABS is indicated by its obligatorily specific interpretation (cf. Bittner, 1994; Wharram, 2003), the ABS case of its stranded modifier, and the concomitant presence of both object ϕ -agreement on the verb and ERG case assigned to the subject. In contrast, objects incorporated under *-qaq* ‘have’ may *never* appear as ABS, (53). This seems to be related to the fact, mentioned earlier in §3.1, that incorporants of *-qaq* ‘have’ (though not of other affixal verbs) are subject to the Definiteness Restriction; this presumably clashes with the specific or definite reading generally associated with ABS objects. Putting these points together, I conclude that, whereas other affixal verbs allow their objects to raise to Spec- vP , thus rendering them visible to higher heads such as Agr^0 , nominals embedded under *-qaq* ‘have’ necessarily remain vP -internal.³⁶

a. Ulak **ujami-liu**-qqau-juq piu-ju-**mik**
 Ulak.ABS necklace-make-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S beautiful-PART-MOD
 ‘Ulak made a beautiful necklace.’

b. Ula-up **ujami-liu**-qqau-**janga** piu-juq
 Ulak-ERG necklace-make-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O beautiful-PART.ABS
 ‘Ulak made this beautiful necklace.’ (CH: Yuan 2025, p. 533)

a. qukiuti-qaq-tunga
gun-have-PART.1SG.S
'I have a gun.'

b. *qukiuti-qaq-**tara**
gun-have-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O
Intended: 'I have this (specific type of) gun.'
(AB)

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We may also compare *-qaq* ‘have’ to other affixal verbs that embed clausal constituents. Recall from §2.2 that the affixal ECM verb *-niraq* ‘say’ embeds a TP complement, as repeated in (54a), and that the embedded subject of such a construction may surface as ABS. Again, unlike *-qaq* ‘have’, the v^0 headed by *-niraq* ‘say’ projects a specifier that allows the embedded subject to be accessible to matrix Agr^0 . A similar point may be made for standalone pseudorelative CPs that serve as complements of perception verbs, as previously seen in §4.2 and repeated in (54b); these too permit embedded subjects to move to the matrix vP edge.³⁷

(54) **ABS subjects of embedded reduced clauses**

- a. Saila-up [TP niri-niar]-nira-qqau-janga [TP Alana
Saila-ERG eat-NR.FUT-say-REC.PST-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O Alana.ABS
tuktu-viniq-mit]
caribou-former-MOD
‘Saila said [TP Alana will be eating caribou meat].’ (SB; Compton 2017a, p. 299)
- b. tautu-qqau-nngit-tara [CP Kiuru inngiq-tuq]
look.at-REC.PST-NEG-PART.1SG.S/3SG.O Carol.ABS sing-PART.ABS
‘I didn’t look at Carol singing.’ (AB)

Lastly, the vP -internal status of nominals embedded under *-qaq* ‘have’ explains the obligatorily antipassive appearance of embedded transitive verbs in the clause-incorporating existential, as seen in examples like (51a). In §2.1, it was mentioned that the antipassive in Inuktitut crucially does not reflect detransitivization or any other change in argument structure (e.g Bok-Bennema, 1991; Johns, 1999, 2001; Spreng, 2006, 2012; Yuan, 2018, 2022). Although previous treatments differ in exactly how the antipassive is syntactically represented, they broadly converge on the idea that the antipassive signals the presence of a low object.³⁸ The ideas outlined this section follow this general intuition. However, the novel contribution of the present discussion is that MOD case does not just mark objects and other internal arguments; rather, it may be assigned to any nominal regardless of its grammatical function or thematic role, so long as it is located within the vP .

* * * *

In this section, I have demonstrated that the clause-incorporating existential construction reifies certain generalizations about the agreement and case system of Inuktitut first introduced in §2.1. In particular, it provides novel evidence that ERG and ABS cases are found only in clauses built up to AgrP , which also explains their tight connection with ϕ -agreement in the clausal periphery. The absence of both ϕ -agreement and ERG and ABS case in clauses embedded under *-qaq* ‘have’ is due to the truncated status of pseudorelative CPs. Nominals associated with incorporated CPs are instead MOD because they are trapped within the vP projected by this verb.

6 Clause incorporation: Theoretical and typological implications

Having established the morphosyntactic structure of the clause-incorporating existential construction, we now turn to the grammatical underpinnings of clause incorporation itself as well as its broader implications for the typology of incorporation. I argue that the ability for clauses to incorporate at all motivates a postsyntactic

³⁷Since the pseudorelative CP in (54b) is also ABS, I assume that the subject DP located in Spec-CP (per the structure in (38), from §4.1), pied-pipes the clause when it raises out of the vP .

³⁸For instance, the analyses of Bok-Bennema 1991, Spreng 2006, 2012, and Yuan 2018 take the antipassive to directly assign MOD case to a low object (MOD case would thus be akin to structural ACC case). In contrast, Basilico 2019 departs from these approaches by proposing that the antipassive head introduces a MOD-marked argument not otherwise part of the argument structure of the verb; however, Basilico’s analysis is not compatible with findings of Yuan 2018 that expletive subjects (i.e., non-arguments) may also be antipassivized.

approach to incorporation (as opposed to one involving syntactic movement), and outline two possible implementations (building on Yuan 2025 and Compton and Pittman 2010, respectively). I also address the very existence of clause incorporation in Inuktitut in light of its typological rarity otherwise.

6.1 Two models of postsyntactic incorporation

Generative accounts of incorporation have largely sought to derive noun-verb incorporation via syntactic movement of the noun (e.g. Baker, 1988, 2009; Baker et al., 2005; Roberts, 2010; Barrie and Mathieu, 2016). Although these accounts have primarily focused on ‘classical’ incorporation taking place optionally between a given transitive verb and its nominal object, Johns (2007b) proposes that obligatory incorporation in the Inuit languages may also be captured under a movement-based analysis. In this account, obligatory incorporation arises from a morphosyntactic requirement that each complex word contain a root. As mentioned in §2.2, Johns takes affixal verbs to be rootless light verbs (v^0 s), so constructions containing such verbs require syntactic movement of a nominal root to be well-formed; in contrast, lexical verbs (V^0 s) are roots themselves so they never trigger noun incorporation.

However, I argue that clause incorporation *cannot* be readily captured in this vein and that morphological approaches to incorporation fare better overall. Such a movement analysis is challenged by the fact that incorporants may also contain functional material. Johns (2007b) mainly investigates the obligatory incorporation of simplex nominal roots, but does consider the incorporation of inflected nominals as in (55). For Johns (p. 562), this is achieved through pied-piping: the root being attracted is actually the postpositional suffix *-kku*, and the inflected nominal is pied-piped by virtue of being contained within the PP.

(55) Incorporation of PP containing inflected nominal

[_{PP} illu-ga-**kku**]-**u**-vutit
house-POSS.1SG-through -V-IND.2SG.S
‘You’re going through my house.’ (L; Johns 2007b, p. 562)³⁹

This idea, however, does not straightforwardly account for clause incorporation, whether that of TPs in ECM constructions such as (14) or of pseudorelative CPs. The reasons for this are multifold. First, as the verbal roots in clause incorporation contexts are encapsulated only by functional material, there is no other outer root that may trigger pied-piping of the entire clausal constituent. Second, because these verbs project their own nominal arguments, there are in principle multiple roots that may incorporate; yet, as seen above, the nominal arguments are always stranded. The root movement analysis does not readily predict that such nominals *cannot* undergo incorporation. Finally, and more broadly, an overarching issue with using any syntactic movement account of incorporation is that it misses the generalization that, in Inuktitut, both nominal and clausal incorporants are *complements* of affixal verbs (Yuan, 2025), i.e., the two are already base-generated as structurally adjacent elements in the syntax. This undermines the need to invoke syntactic movement as a means of bringing the two together.

I propose instead that Inuktitut requires a postsyntactic mechanism for incorporation, in that incorporation takes place in the morphological component of the grammar but takes the syntactic structure as its input.⁴⁰ Below, I outline two different implementations, developed by Yuan (2025) and Compton and Pittman (2010), respectively. As both are broadly able to capture clause incorporation (albeit with different ancillary assumptions), I do not adjudicate between the two in this paper.

³⁹Orthographically, in Labrador Inuttut this form is *illugakkovutit*, with <o> representing /uu/ (which in this example spans a morpheme boundary).

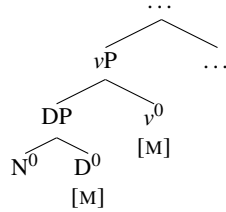
⁴⁰It is also possible that the Autolexical analysis of noun incorporation of Sadock 1985, 1991 may be able to be extended to clause incorporation; under this theory, too, incorporation is a morphological phenomenon, but the morphological component of the grammar operates in tandem with (and autonomously from) the syntactic component. I set this third option aside for space reasons.

6.1.1 Incorporation as Merger

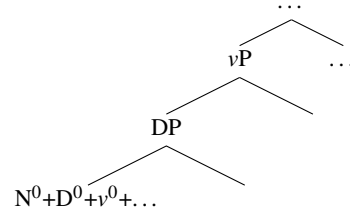
Building on Sadock 1985, 1991 and Bok-Bennema 1991, Yuan 2025 models incorporation using the postsyntactic operation of (Morphological) Merger. For Yuan, the postsyntactic timing of incorporation is motivated by her observation that incorporants may be syntactically active. As previously shown in (29)–(30) in §3.3, nominals that have undergone A-movement may nonetheless undergo incorporation *in situ*, which Yuan attributes to lower copy spell-out driven by the morphological subcategorization requirements of affixal (incorporating) verbs. Merger creates a complex head out of two adjacent heads and realizes these elements as morphologically bound (e.g. Marantz, 1988; Embick and Noyer, 2001; Harizanov and Gribanova, 2019). In noun incorporation constructions, v^0 undergoes Merger with the head of its DP complement; D^0 also undergoes Merger with the head of its own complement, etc. Formalizing Yuan’s idea further, I illustrate the derivations in (56) using the notation introduced in Harizanov and Gribanova 2019: heads that are lexically specified as having to undergo Merger with an adjacent element bear a feature [M].⁴¹ Note that functional heads above v^0 are omitted, though they are also affixal and thus should also be specified as bearing [M].

(56) Accounting for noun incorporation of DPs with Merger

a. Syntax:



b. PF (after Merger):



Importantly, Merger applies between *structurally adjacent* heads, rather than linearly adjacent ones, accounting for the aforementioned observation that only complements may undergo incorporation.⁴² The idea that Merger requires first establishing head-complement relations in the syntax is also crucial to our analysis of clause incorporation, as it allows us to distinguish between the pseudorelative CPs (complements, which incorporate) and genuine relative clause CPs (adjuncts, which do not incorporate). Consider an example such as (22b), repeated as (57a) below. The (simplified) syntax of this construction is represented as (57b). If v^0 is morphologically subcategorized to undergo Merger (i.e., bears [M]), regardless of the syntactic category of its complement, then in the clause-incorporating existential construction the v^0 -*qaq* ‘have’ should undergo Merger with embedded C^0 ; as established in the sections above, the embedded CP is v^0 ’s complement. Since C^0 , T^0 , and other functional heads along the clausal spine are all affixal as well, they too bear [M], causing Merger to apply iteratively between each pair of structurally adjacent heads. Since the embedded verb does not incorporate its complement, it does not bear [M] so Merger does not proceed further.⁴³ The result is a complex verb consisting of

⁴¹As noted by Yuan (2025, p. 529) it does not matter whether Merger proceeds upward like traditional head movement or downward. In (56b), the illustration of Merger as proceeding downward is arbitrary and does not reflect any deeper analytical decisions. In Harizanov and Gribanova 2019, the directionality of Merger is distinguished by the +/- feature values (e.g., [M:+]) and [M:-]); I omit these values in (56b) for convenience.

⁴²Following the distinction from Embick and Noyer 2001, this means that the subtype of Merger invoked here is specifically *Lowering*, which is sensitive to hierarchical order and may thus ignore intervening material such as adjuncts (as opposed to Local Dislocation, which operates on linearly adjacent elements, regardless of their syntactic status). Yuan 2025 additionally suggests that there may be variation within Inuit languages as to which subtype of Merger is relevant, diagnosable by whether non-complements may undergo incorporation. That being said, see §6.1.2 below for a possible challenge to the idea that only structurally adjacent heads along the clausal spine may form complex words.

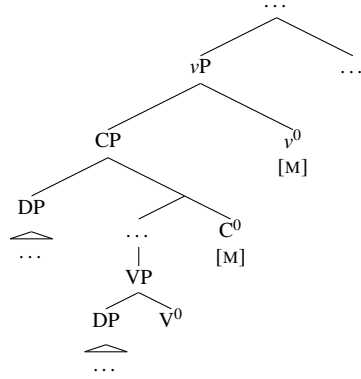
⁴³Following Johns’s (2007b) position that affixal and non-affixal verbs are v^0 s and V^0 s, respectively, we could tentatively generalize that in Inuktitut functional heads bear [M] while lexical heads do not. Alternatively, we may assume that the morphological subcategorization requirement of any given head is completely lexically determined, that is, not predictable by syntactic category (this is possibly more in line with the discussion in Harizanov and Gribanova 2019, pp. 486–487, but they do not consider polysynthetic languages such as Inuktitut). I leave a more detailed consideration of the determinants of affixal vs. standalone elements of Inuktitut for future work.

several functional heads along the matrix and embedded clausal spines, with both nominal arguments surfacing as separate words, (57c).

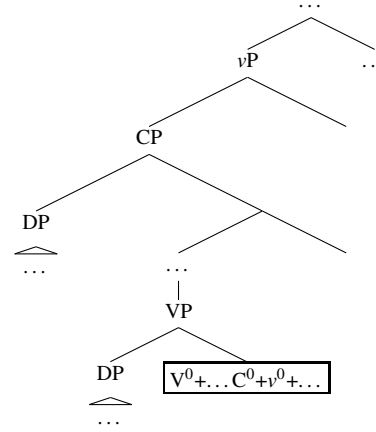
(57) **Deriving clause incorporation**

- a. anguti-mik igalaar-mik surak-si-ju-qaq-tuq
 man-MOD window-MOD break-AP-PART-have-PART.3SG.S
 ‘A man broke the window.’ (AB)

b. Syntax:



c. PF (after Merger):



This account also captures why the nominal pivot is never incorporated in this construction, even though it is also under the scope of the matrix verb. All things being equal, we might expect the highest accessible element in v^0 's c-command domain to incorporate. According to our pseudorelative analysis from §4, the nominal is located in Spec-CP; as it is sometimes assumed that heads and their specifiers are equidistant (e.g. Pesetsky and Torrego, 2001; Hornstein, 2009; Oxford, 2024), it is not immediately obvious on locality grounds alone why v^0 should not undergo Merger with the D^0 of the pseudorelative subject instead of embedded C^0 . However, since the present approach explicitly operates on heads of complements, D^0 is not a viable target by due to the DP's status as a *specifier*.

6.1.2 Incorporants as phonological subwords

An alternative postsyntactic approach to incorporation comes from an influential theory of complex word-formation developed by Compton and Pittman (2010) for the Inuit languages. According to this account, these languages map syntactic phases to single phonological words, and, correspondingly, subphasal elements to sub-word morphology. Compton and Pittman moreover posit that only CPs and DPs are phases; transitive vPs and other elements commonly identified as phasal (e.g., categorizing heads) are crucially not.⁴⁴ Note that, unlike the analysis of Yuan 2025, this approach does not take head-complement relations to be a prerequisite for affixation, since any syntactic element that is not a C or D in category would be realized as morphologically bound. Crucially, this allows for the possibility of phrasal subword material. As discussed by Compton (2012, 2017a), adjectival and adverbial suffixes in the Inuit languages may indeed be plausibly analyzed as (phrasal) adjuncts, as opposed to hierarchically ordered heads along the clausal spine (cf. Cinque, 1999); it is thus unsurprising that they may appear within larger complex words as well, as shown below.⁴⁵

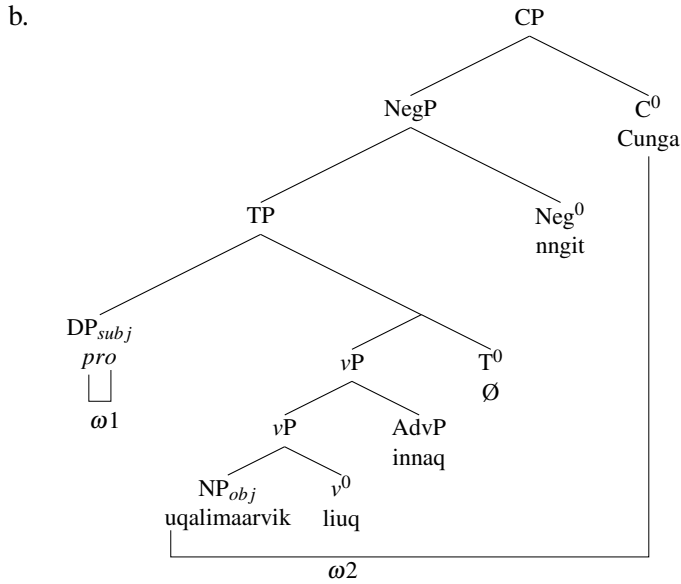
⁴⁴This view is therefore incompatible with proposals for typologically similar languages as containing word-internal phases (e.g. Newell and Piggott, 2014).

⁴⁵In contrast, the account of Yuan 2025 discussed in §6.1.1 above would require that these suffixes be analyzed as heads that individually project along the clausal spine in the sense of Cinque 1999.

To account for noun incorporation, Compton and Pittman assume that incorporated nouns are reduced NPs, rather than DPs, meaning that they are not phasal.⁴⁶ Consider how this analysis captures a sentence as in (58), repeated from (3), which features a complex incorporated object. The subject is a DP, albeit null in this example, so under this analysis it should be prosodified as an independent word. Then, once the CP phase is built, the remainder of the clause is also spelled out. Because the object taken to be a complex NP, it is spelled out with the verbal elements within this phase—resulting in its incorporated appearance.

(58) **Phases as phonological words in Inuktitut**

- a. (pro) **uqa-limaar-vi-liu(ng)-inna-nngit-tunga**
 (1SG.ABS) speak-all.of-LOC.NMLZ-make-always-NEG-PART.1SG.S
 ‘I was not always making libraries.’ (IG; Compton and Pittman 2010, p. 2168)



Under this account, there need not be any syntactic or morphological differences between what we have been referring to as affixal vs. non-affixal verbs, since the (non-)occurrence of incorporation is fully predicted by the syntactic category of the incorporated element. This treatment of word-formation thus makes a strong prediction: all incorporated (non-phasal) elements are structurally smaller than their standalone (phasal) counterparts. In other words, there cannot be some XP that is both able to undergo incorporation and surface as an independent word, depending on the context. Therefore, Compton and Pittman (2010) must assume that incorporated clauses are also structurally smaller than their standalone counterparts. This is immediately obvious with verbal constituents incorporated under ECM verbs, as exemplified in (14); recall that these are TPs at most. Compton and Pittman (p. 2177) do not consider pseudorelative clauses, but do suggest that participial clauses without ϕ -agreement morphology instantiate truncated CPs and are thus non-phasal. Reduced CPs are indeed incorporated in the clause-incorporating existential construction, but the same pseudorelative clauses form independent words when they serve as complements of perception verbs, as seen in (39)-(41) in §4.2. For Compton and Pittman, these standalone pseudorelative clauses must be analyzed as full CP phases, though this is difficult to evaluate empirically based on the available data.

As mentioned above, this paper presents both proposals as viable directions for modeling clause incorporation. What they broadly have in common is that incorporation takes place after the syntactic structure has been built, meaning that the syntax (directly or indirectly) determines what elements are ultimately realized as morphologically bound vs. free. However, a major difference (besides the analytical details contrasted above)

⁴⁶In light of the fact that Inuktitut also permits apparently DP-sized constituents to undergo incorporation, Compton (2013) later suggests that standalone arguments are K(ase)Ps that contain DPs, and that the nominal phase head is K⁰, not D⁰.

pertains to their treatment of polysynthetic languages as a defineable class. Compton and Pittman (2010) do not explicitly cast their analysis as a general framework for polysynthetic word-formation. However, in suggesting that “these languages apply a different level of the prosodic hierarchy to syntactic structure (i.e., phases are mapped to phonological words, as opposed to phonological phrases, as may be the case in other languages)” (p. 2189), it is implied that polysynthetic vs. non-polysynthetic languages may arise from parametric variation in syntax-prosody mappings (indeed, their analysis has been extended to a variety of other polysynthetic languages; see for instance Bliss 2013, Barrie and Mathieu 2016, and Ershova 2020). In contrast, the Merger operation invoked by Yuan (2025) is not specific to polysynthetic languages, as Merger exists as a general device for word-formation. Under the latter theory, we might say that Inuktitut appears polysynthetic due to *most* heads in the language being morphologically specified as affixal (i.e., bearing [M]), but otherwise there is nothing that sets a language like Inuktitut apart from a non-agglutinating language like English. The Merger-based approach thus does not make any strong predictions about morphological typology.

6.2 The rarity of clause incorporation cross-linguistically

At the start of this paper, it was mentioned that the incorporation of CP-sized clauses (as opposed to reduced clauselets) is sufficiently rare cross-linguistically that its existence is debatable begin with. In a typological survey, Olthof (2020a,b) observes that, although many languages permit the incorporation of complex elements, unambiguous cases of clause incorporation are unattested in her sample.⁴⁷ In light of the findings of this paper, then, we may now ask why we *do* find clause incorporation in Inuktitut. That is, what sets apart incorporation in Inuktitut from its counterparts in other languages, such that the incorporation of clauses is derivationally possible in just the former?

Earlier, I have proposed that clause incorporation in Inuktitut arises from the interaction of multiple language-specific factors, all independently motivated above but summarized in (59). The cross-linguistic rarity of clause incorporation could therefore stem from the fact that most other languages do not simultaneously have all of these properties listed below.

(59) Factors contributing to clause incorporation in Inuktitut

- a. Incorporation is obligatory, triggered by the morphological requirements of the language
- b. Incorporation is postsyntactic, rather than syntactically derived
- c. There is an incorporating verb that takes a CP complement

First, recall that incorporation in many of the world’s languages is optional and available with a wide variety of transitive verbs; incorporation, when it occurs, is accordingly often attributed to some syntactic property of the nominal object in question (e.g. Mithun, 1984; Baker, 1988; Heck and Richards, 2010; Roberts, 2010; Barrie and Mathieu, 2016). As a result, most languages with this profile of incorporation tend to only exhibit *noun incorporation*, as opposed to the incorporation of non-nominal constituents (though see Barrie and Li 2012, McKenzie 2022, a.o. for examples of the latter). In these languages, then, we may not expect to find clause incorporation to begin with. In contrast, Inuktitut exhibits obligatory incorporation with a closed class of verbs, and crucially membership in this class is not based on any selectional restrictions of the verbs in question; we have already seen that they may incorporate complex nominal and verbal elements alike. Additionally,

⁴⁷This may partly be due to how clause incorporation is defined for Olthof (2020a,b). For instance, in her survey, the bolded sequence in (i) counts as an incorporated inflected word rather than an incorporated clause, even though it presumably corresponds to a complex syntactic constituent that is built up to the CP level.

(i) Incorporated clause vs. ‘inflected word’

am-m-ihchiss-úu-waa-chiil-uu-k

REL-1A-rest-1A.PL-look.for-PL-DECL

‘We’re looking for a place where we can rest.’ (Crow; Graczyk 2007, p. 281)

Although there are other languages with obligatory incorporation (see fn. 9) for a non-exhaustive sample), this obligatoriness may be due to a variety of other reasons. In Southern Tiwa (Tanoan), for instance, whether incorporation is required depends partly on the animacy of the nominal object (e.g. Allen et al., 1984; Rosen, 1990; Heck and Richards, 2010). Therefore, it is most instructive to compare Inuktitut with other obligatorily incorporating languages that specifically have the properties listed in (59). Interestingly, the Wakashan language Nuuchahnulth is similar to Inuktitut in that certain verbs are affixal and may take a variety of complements, including clausal ones, yet Nuuchahnulth still does not permit clauses to be morphologically incorporated. As shown in (60a-b), the affixal verb *-nakuuḥ[+L]* ‘observe’ may syntactically embed a reduced vP or a CP—however, only the former may actually morphologically incorporate into the verb. When the complement of this verb is a CP, a “dummy” placeholder surfaces instead, as in (60b), presumably so that the affixal verb still has a morphological host. It is impossible to incorporate any element associated with the embedded clause, including the complementizer, (60c).

a. [_{VP} **tuux^w-a[+R]**]-nakuuḥ[+L]-mit-siiš suw'a
jump-ITER -observe-PST-1SG.IND you
'I observed you jumping.'

b. **?u-nakuuḥ[+L]**-mit-siiš [_{CP} ?in tuux^w-a[+R]-mit-suuk]
DUMMY-observe-PST-1SG.IND COMP jump-ITER-PST-2SG.DEP
'I observed that you were jumping.'

c. ***?in-nakuuḥ[+L]**-mit-siiš tuux^w-a[+R]-mit-suuk
COMP-observe-PST-1SG.IND jump-ITER-PST-2SG.DEP
Intended: 'I observed that you were jumping.' (Nuuchahnulth; Wojdak 2008, pp. 65, 192)

7 Conclusion

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